CORE

THE SINGLE ORGANIZING IDEA

PLAYBOOK

A practical guide to the SOI® Methodology

NG&A Associate Edition

NG&A | SOI

TURNING PURPOSE INTO PRACTICE.

Many organisations can describe their purpose.
Far fewer are driven by one.

NG&A helps leadership teams embed purpose.
Properly aligning governance, strategy and culture to drive growth and sustainable progress.

NG&A | SOI™

This edition of *CORE: The Playbook* has been produced exclusively for Associates, consultants, and collaborators working with Neil Gaught & Associates (NG&A).

It is intended to provide a foundation understanding of the Single Organizing Idea (SOI®) methodology and the principles that underpin our work with clients.

The methodology described within these pages represents an important stage in the evolution of SOI®. While the fundamentals remain unchanged, the framework continues to evolve through practical application, ongoing research, the development of ISO 37011 Guidance for the Governance of Organisations by Purpose, and the emergence of artificial intelligence as a transformative business capability.

This edition should therefore be viewed as a working guide rather than a definitive statement of the methodology.

A NOTE TO NG&A ASSOCIATES & CONTRACTORS

Throughout this journey, many thousands of people have participated in the development of the thinking. Their experiences, challenges, questions, successes and failures have helped shape and refine the methodology that appears in these pages.

When *CORE*: *How a Single Organizing Idea Can Change Business for Good* with Routledge in 2017, the objective was simple: To demonstrate that business could become a far more powerful force for positive change if commercial success and societal value were treated not as competing objectives but as mutually reinforcing outcomes.

The book was shortlisted for the UK Business Book of the Year Awards and introduced the Single Organizing Idea (SOI®) to a global audience. Three years later, *CORE*: *The Playbook* was published as a practical guide designed to help organisations identify, define, align and measure purpose in a way that was both actionable and commercially relevant. The origins of SOI® stretch back much further.

The concept was first conceived in New Zealand and has evolved over more than two decades through practical application, experimentation and collaboration. It is not the product of theory alone. Rather, it represents the accumulated learning of thousands of conversations, interviews, workshops and consulting engagements involving business leaders, employees, academics, entrepreneurs, investors, public sector organisations, charities and community groups from many different countries, cultures and backgrounds.

Throughout this journey, many thousands of people have participated in the development of the thinking. Their experiences, questions, successes and failures have helped shape and refine the methodology that appears in these pages.

SOI® has also benefited from collaboration with individuals and organisations operating at every level of society. Contributions from business, academia and the social sector have all helped strengthen the framework and ensure it remains practical, relevant and capable of delivering real-world outcomes.

Today there are organisations of all sizes, operating across a wide variety of sectors and geographies, that have used SOI® to make purpose real. While every organisation is unique, the lesson has been remarkably consistent. Purpose only creates value when it is translated into decisions, behaviours, systems, culture and governance.

Purpose is often portrayed as idealistic. Business is often portrayed as pragmatic. In reality, successful organisations require both. The role of SOI® has always been to provide a bridge between idealism and pragmatism; between what an organisation believes and what it actually does.

Over the years, the thinking has attracted support and encouragement from some of the world's most respected business thinkers and practitioners, including John Elkington, conceiver of the Triple Bottom Line; Charles Handy, one of the most influential management thinkers of modern times; and Rob Markey, co-conceiver of the Net Promoter System. Their support, along with that of many other leaders, academics and practitioners, has helped reinforce the belief that organisations can achieve better commercial outcomes by creating greater value for society.

Since the publication of this Playbook in 2020, the context in which organisations operate has changed dramatically.

The pandemic accelerated existing trends. Expectations of business continue to evolve. Purpose has moved steadily from the margins towards the mainstream.

Most significantly, artificial intelligence is reshaping how organisations gather insight, make decisions, create value and compete. What has not changed is the need for clarity.

The organisations most likely to thrive in the years ahead will not be those with the most technology. They will be those

with the clearest understanding of why they exist, who they serve and the difference they seek to make.

Today, artificial intelligence increasingly supports both the development and delivery of NG&A solutions. We use it to accelerate research, identify patterns, challenge assumptions, test ideas, analyse information and improve the quality and speed of strategic thinking.

However, technology remains an enabler, not a substitute for judgement, wisdom, empathy, experience or, of course, leadership.

When describing the development of an SOI®, I often explain that the process combines three elements: Truth. Informed intuition. Intelligent synthesis.

Artificial intelligence can help us discover truth more quickly. It can assist in synthesising information more effectively. But informed intuition, contextual understanding and human judgement remain essential. Purpose remains the organising principle. AI is an accelerator.

The emergence of artificial intelligence has therefore increased rather than diminished the importance of SOI®. As organisations navigate unprecedented technological change, SOI® provides the organising logic through which governance, culture, systems, innovation and stakeholder value can be aligned.

This edition has been produced exclusively for Associates, consultants, contractors and collaborators working with Neil Gaught & Associates.

It should be viewed as a working guide rather than a definitive statement of the methodology. The principles remain constant, but the thinking continues to evolve through client work, ongoing research, and the collective experience of those applying the framework around the world.

As you work with clients, remember that our task is not simply to help organisations define purpose. It is to help them operationalise it. That is the challenge — and the opportunity.

Neil Gaught, Auckland, June 2026

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SOI™

SINGLE ORGANIZING IDEA

1.0

1-20

SOI® 101

What SOI® is, why it matters and how to apply it in practice.

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1.1 BEYOND PURPOSE

Let's be clear from the start; having a purpose will not save the world, nor will it automatically transform an organisation. Over the past two decades, purpose has become one of the most talked-about ideas in business. Organisations of every size now publish purpose statements, values and commitments that promise to make a positive difference. Yet many struggle to turn those aspirations into meaningful action.

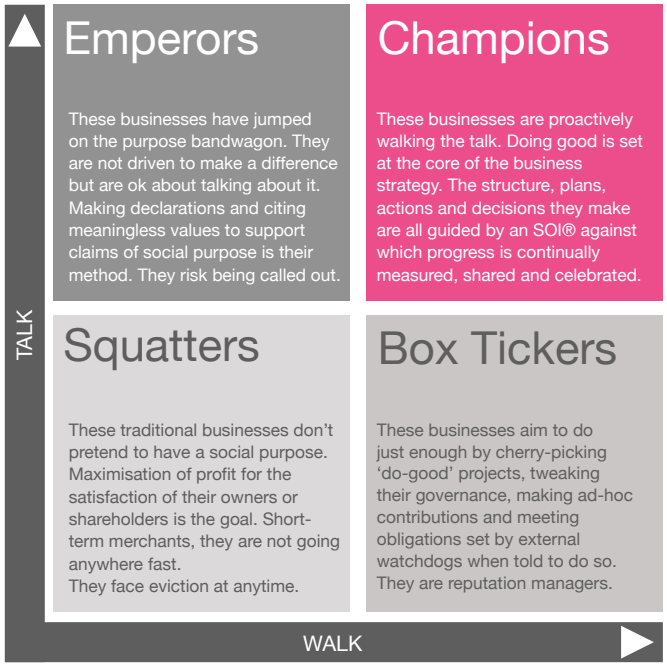
One of the earliest examples was BP's repositioning as "Beyond Petroleum". The ambition was bold, but the gap between what was said and what was done ultimately undermined its credibility. The lesson was not that purpose is flawed, but that purpose without alignment is little more than rhetoric.

This remains a challenge today. Many organisations view purpose as a communications exercise rather than a strategic one. Growth remains the primary objective, performance is measured largely in financial terms and purpose sits on the sidelines rather than at the centre of decision-making.

Others go further by supporting good causes, improving governance and investing in sustainability initiatives. While commendable, these activities are often separate from core strategy rather than the reason for the organisation's existence.

A Single Organizing Idea (SOI®) is different. An SOI® is not a statement or campaign. It is a call to action that aligns people, resources and decisions around a shared objective. It provides clarity, focus and direction, helping organisations navigate complexity while creating value for both society and themselves.

The SOI® methodology was developed to help organisations move beyond talking about purpose and towards embedding it in the way they think, decide, act and measure success.



Walking the talk There is a big difference between what gets said and what gets done. Turning a blind eye, not totally committing or just doing enough is a risky business.

Purpose agnostic	Purpose influenced	SOI® aligned
Pyramidic, silo structure	Pyramidic, silo structure	Flat, networked ecosystem
Top-down control	Top-down control	Self-organizing operating system
Supply-chains	Supply-chains	Value-chains
Short-term profit focus	Short-term profit focus	Long-term thrive focus
Employee indifference	Employee engagement	Employee fulfilment
Efficiency and process driven	Brand comms and CSR combine to win preference through selected customer ‘experiences’	Call to action at the core
Reputation management	Brand promises and brand values drive ‘surface’ culture	Encourages and facilitates a regenerative, circular ecosystem
Sales and marketing communications aimed at winning customers	‘Win-win’ projects make money	Deep, holistic commitment to meaningful values
CSR ‘bolted on’	Sophisticated market share measuring tools	Collaboration culture
Success is financial	Success is financial	Sophisticated alignment/impact measuring tools
		Success is sustainable
Fit for little	**Fit for some**	**Fit for all**

Stuck in the middle with you. Many companies state that they have a purpose but the evidence suggests that not all of them act on it. Big businesses have been called out.

1.2 THE POWER OF A SINGLE STRATEGY

SOI® has three qualities, accurately reflected in its name:

1. **Single** – one clear direction.

2. **Organizing** – systematic coordination.

3. **Idea** – a concept that benefits all.

The first of these is perhaps the most important.

Single
At its core, strategy is about focus. It is the means by which an organisation moves from where it is today to where it wants to be tomorrow. While strategy is often presented as something complex, the fundamental principle is simple: clarity of direction drives better decisions.

The challenge is that many organisations lack a clear strategic focus. Some have no strategy at all. Others attempt to pursue multiple, often competing, objectives at the same time. The result is confusion, fragmented decision-making and wasted effort.

A Single Organizing Idea (SOI®) addresses this problem by bringing economic and societal objectives together within one coherent strategy. Rather than treating commercial success and positive impact as separate agendas, it aligns them around a single call to action.

This is important because organisations increasingly operate in a world where stakeholders expect more than short-term financial performance. Employees seek meaning, customers expect responsibility, investors look for resilience and society demands accountability.

An SOI® provides a framework for responding to these expectations without losing strategic focus. It helps leadership teams decide what to prioritise, what to stop doing and where to invest time, energy and resources.
The objective is not to do more things. The objective is to do the right things, consistently and with purpose.

That is the power of a single strategy.


Economic strategy
Social strategy
Sustainable progress for all

1.3 SELF-ORGANISING SYSTEM

Organizing
The second quality of SOI® is its ability to organise.

Traditional organisations are typically structured around functions such as people and culture, innovation, products and services, communications, sales and marketing, and systems and processes.

While this approach can create efficiency, it can also lead to siloed thinking, competing priorities and fragmented decision-making.

An SOI® provides an alternative. Rather than asking functions to pursue their own objectives, it aligns them around a shared objective. The SOI® becomes the organising principle against which decisions, investments, priorities and performance are assessed.

This does not mean removing functions or hierarchy. It means ensuring that every part of the client organisation understands how it contributes to the same overarching goal.

The result is greater alignment, improved collaboration and more consistent decision-making. People are better able to understand not only what they are doing, but why they are doing it.

For leadership teams, an SOI® provides a powerful filter through which opportunities, risks and competing priorities can be evaluated. For employees, it creates clarity, meaning and direction. For stakeholders, it provides a more coherent and consistent experience.

The practical challenge of implementation is therefore not creating new structures, but aligning existing structures around a common purpose and direction.

This is where SOI® moves beyond strategy and becomes an operating system for the entire organisation. It provides the framework for making purpose real by translating aspiration into action and intention into impact. Purpose is no longer something the organisation talks about; it becomes something actively delivered and effectively governed by.

SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT GOALS

Helping put the ball in the net The Sustainable Development Goals address the global challenges we face, including those related to poverty, inequality, climate change, environmental degradation, peace and justice.

Communications
Smart internal and external communications that remind, support and underline the value of the SOI®, engage stakeholders with it and invite contributions to it.

People & culture
Challenging long-held rituals and hard-nosed business attitudes and aligning them with an idea that humanises is tough. A relevant and compelling SOI® that people care about and have contributed to defining helps shape a more satisfying and rewarding way of working together.



Products & services
Sustainable improvements are primarily delivered through the quality and performance of products and services. Alignment with an SOI® ensures stakeholder needs, wants and values are met.

Innovation
Understanding the core objective of the business helps it decide where it should (and shouldn't) invest its new thinking – what it should start, stop and keep doing.

Systems & processes
The way in which businesses manage quality and efficiency is a reflection of their values. Establishing and reinforcing best practice through the lens of an SOI® uncovers new and better ways of doing things that build a positive reputation.

Sales & marketing
Alignment with an SOI® ensures consistency and impact throughout the design, development and implementation of sales and marketing processes and techniques.

A holistic solution Instead of organizing around functions, SOI® reengineers organisations so the functions organise around the SOI®, making it less siloed, top-down and more focused.

1.4 IDEAS FOR GOOD

Idea
Every organisation starts with an idea.

Some are born from an opportunity, others from a problem that needs solving or an ambition to make things better. Whatever its origin, the idea provides the initial spark that brings people, resources and energy together.

Over time, however, many organisations lose sight of that original idea. As they grow, operational pressures, competing priorities and short-term demands can begin to dominate decision-making. The reason the organisation exists becomes less visible and, in some cases, forgotten altogether.

SOI® places the core idea back at the centre of the organisation.

It does so by ensuring that decisions, investments, priorities and actions are guided by a single organising principle.

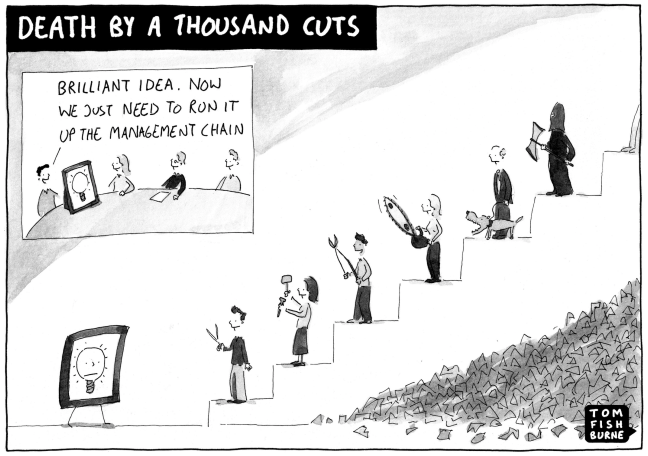
The idea becomes more than an aspiration; it becomes a practical reference point for how the organisation creates value and measures success.

The most powerful ideas share several characteristics. They are relevant, meaningful and useful. They solve real problems, inspire action and encourage contribution from others.

Most importantly, they endure. While products, technologies, markets and management practices may change, a strong idea remains relevant because the need it addresses continues to matter.

This is why identifying the right SOI® is so important. When an organisation is organised around an idea that benefits both itself and the wider world, it gains a powerful source of focus, resilience and long-term relevance.

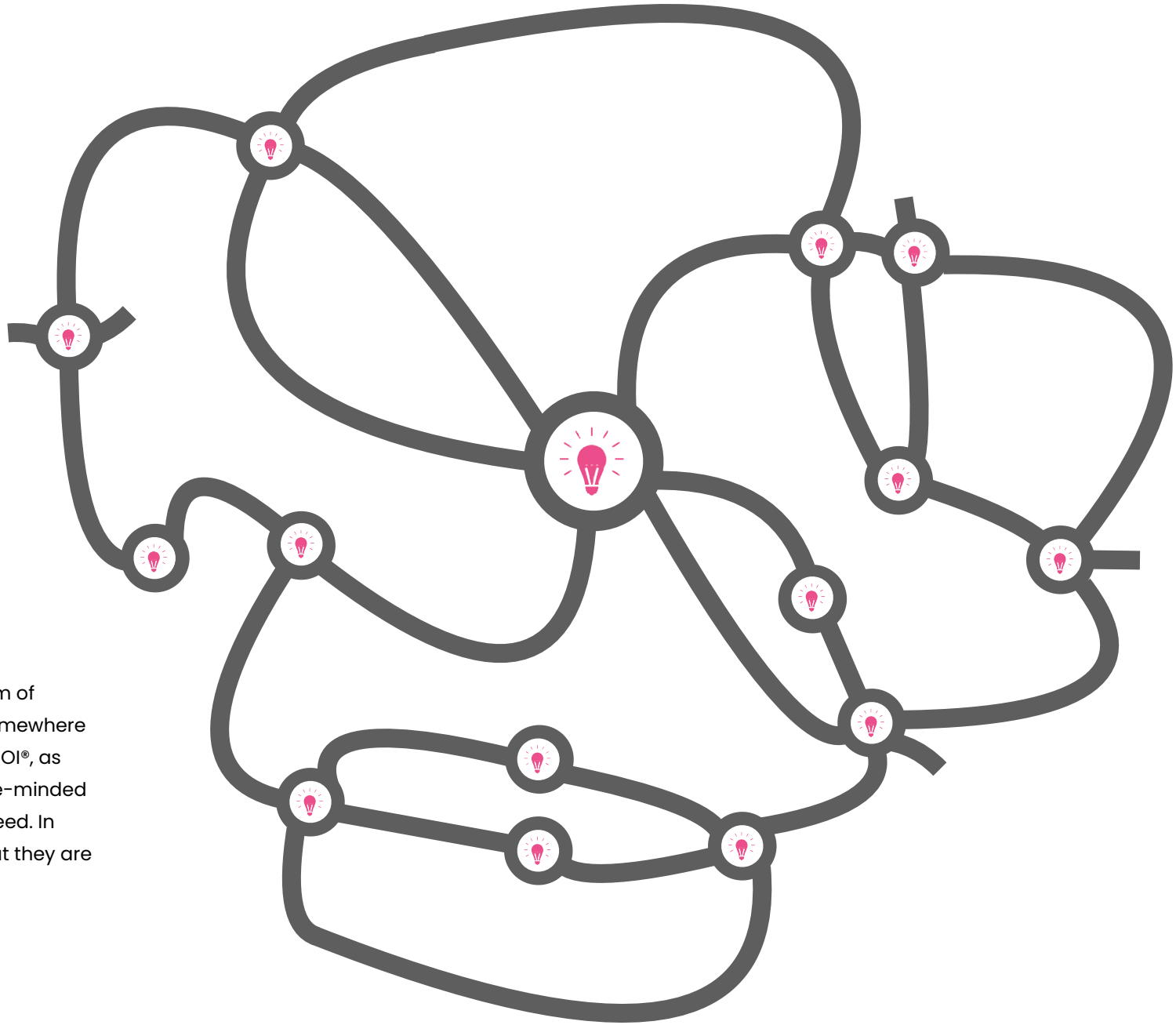
As filmmaker Christopher Nolan observed:



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"An idea can transform the world and rewrite all the rules."

The organisations best equipped for the future will be those built around ideas that are worth pursuing, sharing and sustaining.



Self-organizing FLAT Ecosystem

There's no such thing as a totally flat organisation. There has to be some form of command and control coming from somewhere and leadership is a key component of SOI®, as you will see. But high-performing, single-minded organisations can be very, very flat indeed. In such organisations everyone knows that they are contributing, there's a shared sense of ownership, and unnecessary top-down bureaucracy is avoided at all costs.

1.5 EVERYONE BENEFITS

Traditional approaches to business often focus on serving the interests of a single group, typically owners or shareholders.

While financial performance remains important, organisations that focus exclusively on one stakeholder group can find themselves creating challenges for others.

SOI® takes a broader view.

By aligning commercial and societal objectives within a single strategy, it encourages organisations to create value for all those who contribute to, depend upon or are affected by their activities.

This includes employees, customers, suppliers, partners, investors, communities and the environment.

This wider view is not idealistic. It reflects the reality that organisations operate within interconnected systems. Decisions made in one part of the business can have consequences throughout the value chain and beyond. A procurement decision may affect suppliers. A product decision may affect customers and communities. A culture decision may affect employees, performance and reputation.

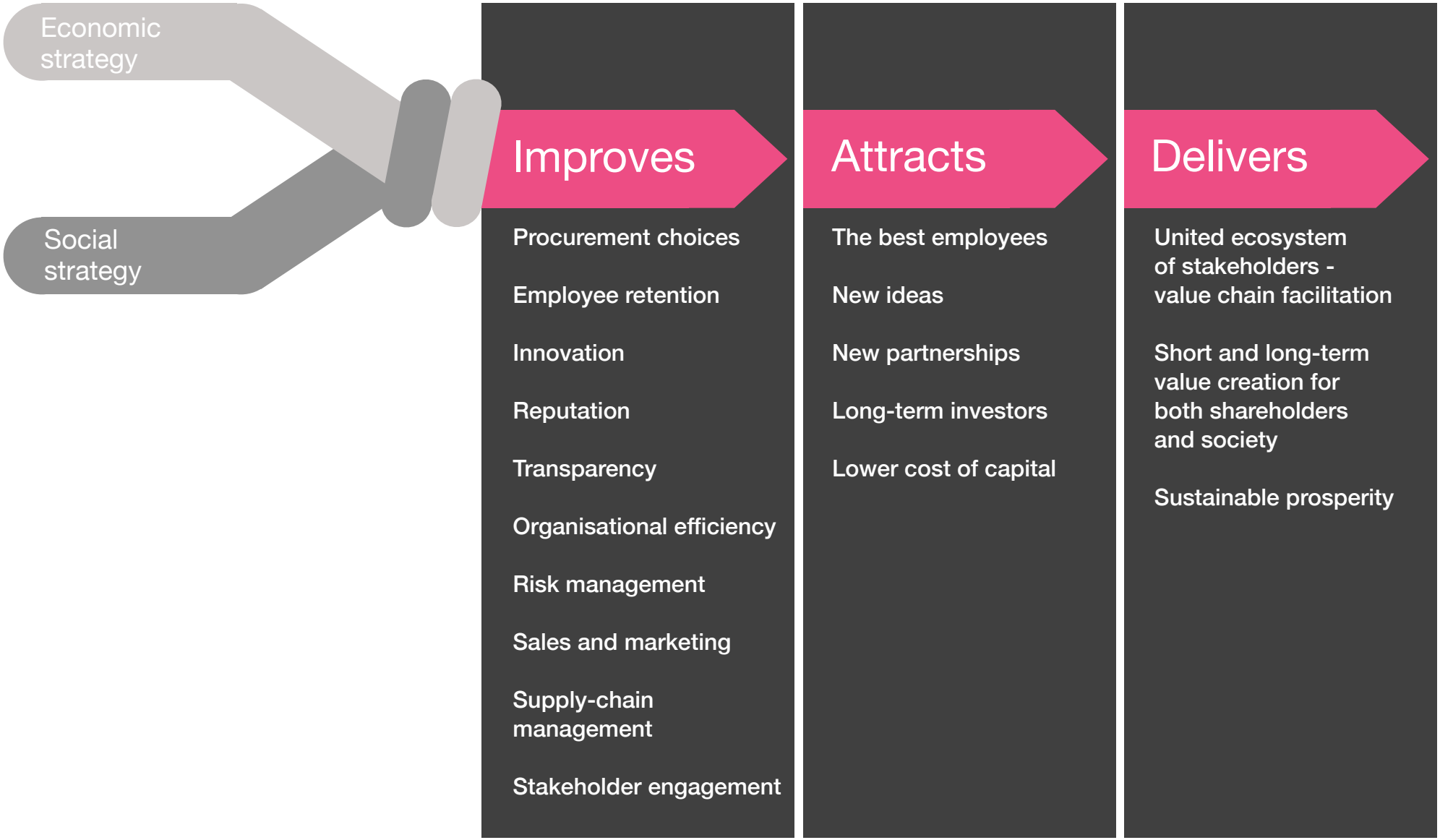
This does not mean every stakeholder receives the same outcome, nor does it mean difficult trade-offs disappear. Rather, it recognises that long-term success is more likely when value is created and shared across the wider ecosystem.

When stakeholders benefit, organisations tend to benefit too. Employees are more engaged, customers become more loyal, suppliers become stronger partners, investors gain confidence and communities become more supportive. This creates a reinforcing cycle. Stronger relationships improve trust. Greater trust encourages collaboration. Collaboration creates opportunities for innovation, resilience and shared progress. Over time, the organisation becomes better able to anticipate risks, respond to change and identify opportunities that would be difficult to see from a narrow shareholder-only perspective.

The result is a more resilient organisation, better equipped to navigate change and respond to emerging opportunities and challenges.

This principle sits at the heart of SOI®. The objective is not to create winners and losers, but to create sustainable progress that benefits as many people as possible while ensuring the long-term success of the organisation itself.

In a connected world, organisations thrive when the ecosystems around them thrive too.


Economic strategy
Social strategy
Improves
Procurement choices
Employee retention
Innovation
Reputation
Transparency
Organisational efficiency
Risk management
Sales and marketing
Supply-chain management
Stakeholder engagement
Attracts
The best employees
New ideas
New partnerships
Long-term investors
Lower cost of capital
Delivers
United ecosystem of stakeholders - value chain facilitation
Short and long-term value creation for both shareholders and society
Sustainable prosperity

1.6 YOUR GUIDING STAR

For centuries, sailors used the stars to navigate vast distances across unfamiliar oceans. They provided a fixed point of reference against which direction could be established and progress measured.

An SOI® performs a similar role.

In a world characterised by uncertainty, complexity and constant change, organisations are faced with an endless stream of decisions, opportunities, risks and competing priorities. Without a clear point of reference, it becomes easy to lose focus, waste resources or drift away from what matters most.

The challenge is not usually a lack of activity. Most organisations are busy. The challenge is ensuring that activity is directed towards the right destination. Markets shift, technologies evolve, leadership teams change and stakeholder expectations continue to rise. In these conditions, organisations need more than plans, targets or statements of intent. They need an organising idea that helps them make sense of complexity and act with confidence.

An SOI® provides that reference point. It acts as a guiding star against which decisions, investments, behaviours and actions can be tested. When faced with a difficult choice, leaders can ask a simple question: Does this help advance our SOI®?

If the answer is yes, the decision is likely to support the organisation's long-term direction. If the answer is no, it may need to be challenged, adapted or abandoned.

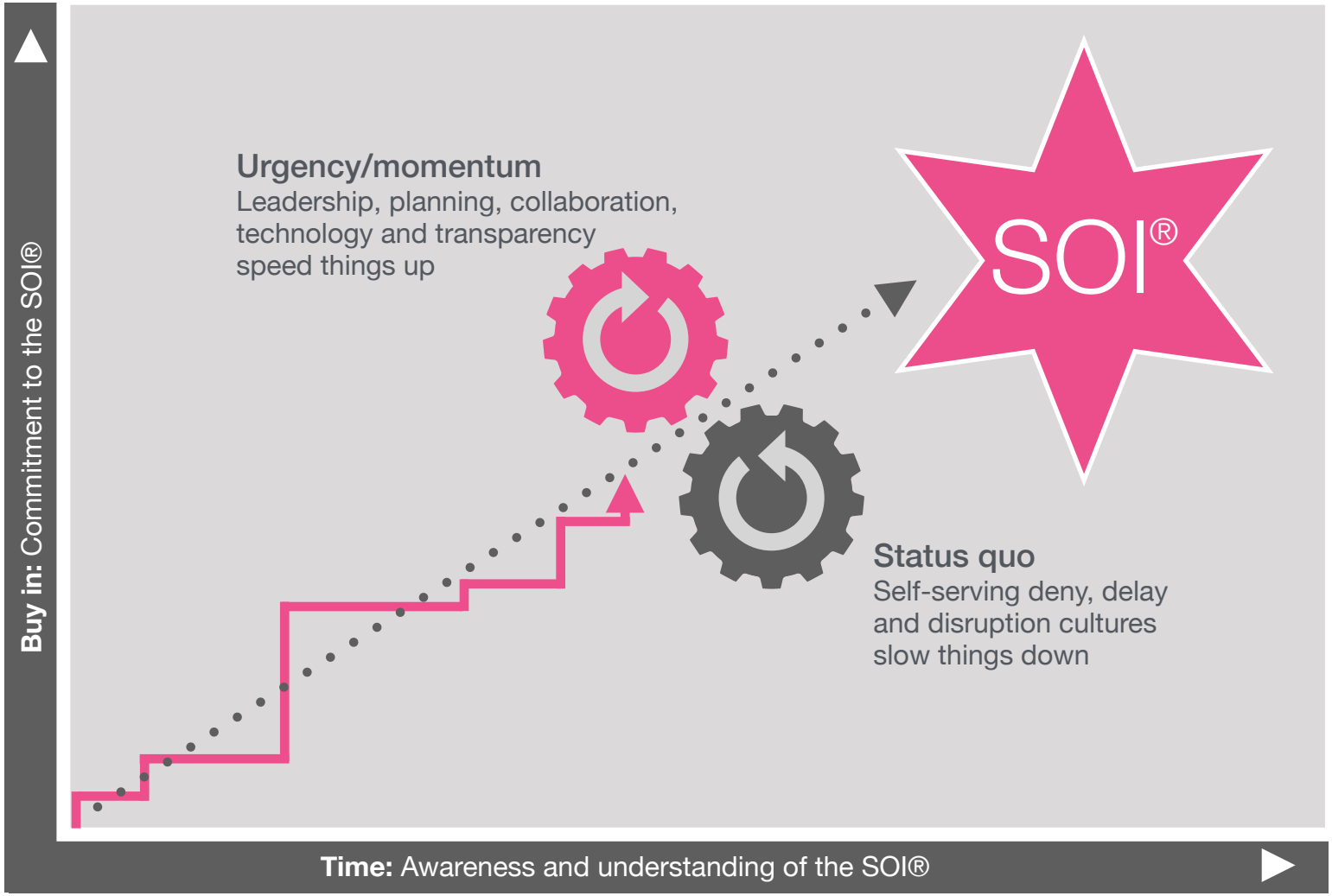
This clarity is one of the greatest strengths of the SOI® methodology. It helps organisations prioritise resources, align stakeholders and remain focused on what matters most, even when circumstances change.

It also helps reduce ambiguity. When people across an organisation understand the same point of reference, they are better able to make decisions without waiting for constant instruction from above. The SOI® creates shared direction while allowing teams and individuals to act with initiative, judgement and accountability.

Importantly, a guiding star is not a destination. It is a constant point of reference that helps an organisation navigate towards its desired future.

The stronger and clearer the SOI®, the easier it becomes to make consistent decisions, maintain alignment and create lasting value.

That is why an effective SOI® is far more than a statement of intent. It becomes a practical tool for leadership, decision-making and governance.



There are lots of stars in the sky, choosing the right one helps organisations achieve their objectives.

1.7 SOI® AT WORK - EXAMPLES

One of the strengths of SOI® is its versatility. The methodology can be applied to organisations of almost any size, sector or geography.

It is not limited to commercial businesses. SOI® thinking has been successfully applied to international NGOs, not-for-profit associations, public bodies, one-off projects and even places. The common factor is not what an organisation does, but its willingness to align people, resources and decisions around a shared idea that benefits both itself and the wider world.

Catholic Relief Services is one of the world's largest international NGOs, employing thousands of people across multiple continents. Despite differences in geography, culture, role and faith, its people are united by a common commitment to creating a better world.

The organisation demonstrates how a clearly defined idea can align diverse stakeholders around a shared objective.

Dutch logistics company Europool System distributes fruit and vegetables throughout Europe. Guided by the purpose of 'maximising circular values,' it has embedded sustainability into the heart of its operations. The result has been innovation, talent attraction, new commercial opportunities and recognition as a leader in its field.

In the fashion sector, Britain's Community Clothing and Canada's Norden provide further examples. Both have built their organisations around ideas that extend beyond products alone, creating social, environmental and economic value while remaining commercially viable.

Large organisations can benefit too. PepsiCo's *Performance with Purpose*, IBM's *Smarter Planet* and Unilever's *Sustainable Living Plan* all demonstrate attempts to align commercial success with broader societal outcomes. While their approaches differ, each reflects the growing recognition that long-term success depends upon creating value for more than shareholders alone.

The lesson is simple. Organisations that thrive over time tend to be organised around an idea that provides clarity, focus and direction. The role of SOI® is to help identify, define, align and measure that idea so it can be translated into meaningful action and sustainable progress.

SINGLE ORGANIZING IDEA (SOI®)	TYPE	ORGANISATION
Enabling Change	Inclusive business network/platform	IBAN
Partners for Good	American INGO	Global Communities
Collective Success	New Zealand tax collection technology	DataTorque
Promote and Protect	Global human rights organisation	UNHCR - GANHRI
Pride	British clothing manufacturer	Community Clothing
Believing in Better	American faith-based INGO	Catholic Relief Services
Mining the Resource. Enriching the Nation	Anglo/African mining company	Debswana
Stewarding Greater Value	Commercial property	Mackersy Property
Building Better Communities	New Zealand construction company	Hawkins
Assuring Confidence	American accreditation organisation	ABET
Waste	Canadian apparel manufacturer	Norden
Maximising Circular Value	Dutch logistic company	Euro Pool System

1.8 A VERY HUMAN APPROACH

Despite the frameworks, tools and processes described throughout this Playbook, SOI® is fundamentally a human endeavour.

The most effective SOI®s are not created by consultants, leadership teams or artificial intelligence working in isolation.

They emerge through listening, collaboration, challenge and shared understanding. They are discovered and refined through conversations with the people who know the organisation best and those who are affected by its decisions and actions.

This requires curiosity, openness and trust. The process will often reveal overlooked strengths, untapped opportunities and, occasionally, uncomfortable truths. For this reason, successful projects depend as much on leadership, engagement and participation as they do on analysis and planning.

For Associates, the role is not to arrive with answers. It is to facilitate discovery, challenge assumptions, bring structure to complexity and help the client organisation uncover insights that already exist within its ecosystem.

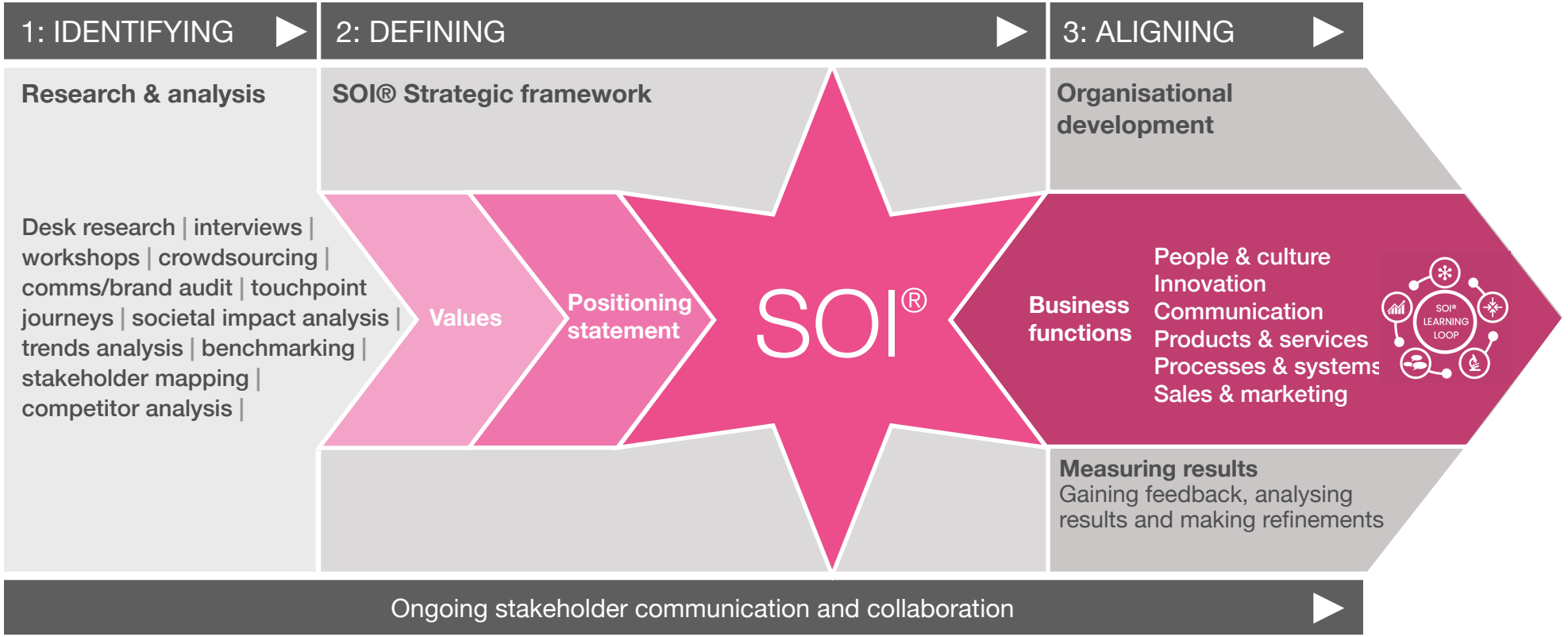
Artificial intelligence can accelerate research, analyse stakeholder feedback, identify patterns, explore future scenarios and reduce administrative effort. Used well, it can improve efficiency and expand the range of insights available to both advisors and client organisations.

However, AI cannot replace human judgement, experience, empathy or trust. It cannot build relationships, navigate organisational politics or determine what is right for a particular organisation.

Technology can support the process, but the success of SOI® ultimately depends on the quality of the conversations, decisions and relationships that shape it.

The next stage of the journey is to identify the organisation's SOI®. This begins by bringing together the right people, establishing a project plan and carrying out a thorough exploration of the organisation, its stakeholders and the environment in which it operates.

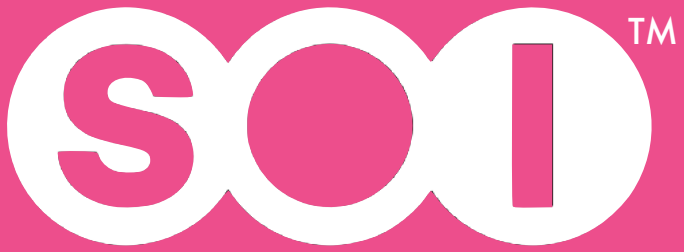
Like any successful project, preparation matters. Once the team is in place and the plan agreed, the process of discovery can begin.


1: IDENTIFYING
2: DEFINING
3: ALIGNING
Research & analysis
Desk research | interviews | workshops | crowdsourcing | comms/brand audit | touchpoint journeys | societal impact analysis | trends analysis | benchmarking | stakeholder mapping | competitor analysis |
SOI® Strategic framework
Values
Positioning statement
SOI®
Business functions
People & culture
Innovation
Communication
Products & services
Processes & systems
Sales & marketing
SOI® LEARNING LOOP
Organisational development
Measuring results
Gaining feedback, analysing results and making refinements
Ongoing stakeholder communication and collaboration

KEY POINTS

- Purpose alone is not enough. Sustainable success requires purpose to be translated into strategy, decisions, behaviours and measurable outcomes.
- SOI® brings commercial and societal objectives together within a single strategy, creating clarity, focus and direction for the entire organisation.
- By aligning people, resources and systems around a shared idea, SOI® acts as both an operating system and a framework for making purpose real.
- Organisations that create value for multiple stakeholders are more likely to build resilience, trust and long-term success.
- While technology and AI can accelerate insight and learning, the discovery and implementation of an SOI® remains a fundamentally human process built on leadership, collaboration and trust.

YOUR NOTES



SINGLE

ORGANIZING

IDEA

2.0

21-44

IDENTIFY

The research tools and stakeholder engagement techniques used to identify an organisation's SOI®.

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2.1 DESK RESEARCH

Before shaping an SOI®, it is important to understand where the client organisation is today and the external factors likely to influence its future.

A useful way to think about this is through the lens of climate rather than weather. Weather forecasts describe short-term conditions; climate forecasts identify the longer-term trends and forces that shape the environment in which an organisation operates.

Some of these factors will be sector specific. What new products, services or business models are emerging? How might they change customer expectations, create competitive advantage or disrupt existing markets?

A useful framework for this exercise is PESTLE analysis, which explores the Political, Economic, Social, Technological, Legal and Environmental factors likely to influence the organisation's future. How might these forces affect trading conditions, talent attraction, investor expectations and customer behaviour?

Two forces are likely to affect almost every organisation: technology and sustainability. What opportunities and challenges will they create for the client organisation?

Directing the project team to explore these issues will help build a picture of the future and provide an important context against which SOI® options can later be tested and evaluated.

Benchmarking

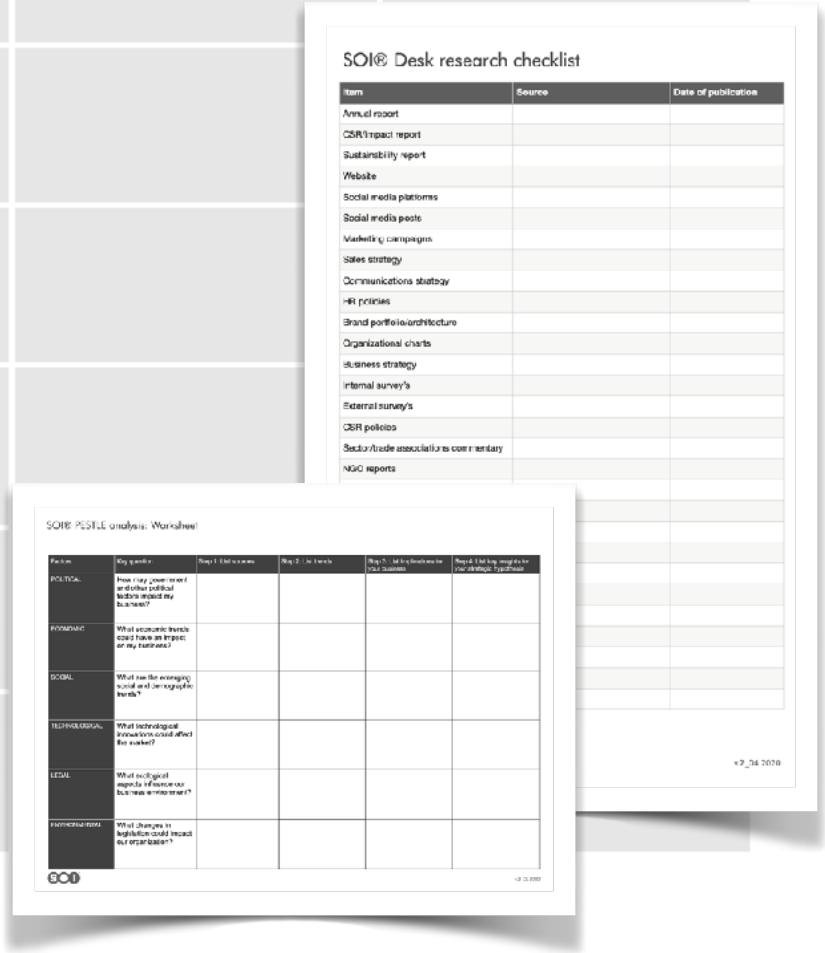
An experienced advisor will bring knowledge and examples from other sectors. Benchmarking helps establish not only what is possible, but also how it might be achieved.

It is also an effective way to reduce perceived risk. Relevant examples of success and failure can provide reassurance, highlight potential challenges and demonstrate the benefits of change. Adapting proven ideas from elsewhere often helps stakeholders become more confident about new directions.

When identifying and defining an SOI®, useful benchmarks can come from unexpected places. Some of the most valuable insights are often drawn from organisations operating in entirely different sectors but facing similar strategic, cultural or stakeholder challenges.

The findings should be distilled into a concise slide deck that summarises the research, highlights key themes and, most importantly, captures the insights that will inform the next stage of the process.

SOI® PESTLE analysis				
Factors	Key question	Step 1: List trends	Step 2: List implications for your business	Step 3: List key insights to help create an overall premise
POLITICAL	How may government and other political factors impact my business?			
ECONOMIC	What economic trends could have an impact on my business?			
SOCIAL	What are the emerging social and demographic trends?			
TECHNOLOGICAL	What technological innovations could affect the market?			
LEGAL	What changes in legislation could impact my business?			
ENVIRONMENTAL	What ecological aspects influence the business?			



PESTLE analysis helps identify the external forces that will influence the viability and relevance of future SOI® options.

2.2 WORKSHOPS

Workshops are a critical part of the SOI® process. They help uncover what is in the hearts and minds of employees and key stakeholders, providing insights into current perceptions, future aspirations, strengths and weaknesses.

The workshop format described here has been used successfully across multiple sectors, cultures and countries. Its effectiveness lies in creating an open environment that encourages participation, collaboration and self-discovery.

By setting a context for change and then inviting participants to explore the organisation as individuals, teams and a collective group, workshops consistently reveal a gap between how people perceive the organisation today and how they would like it to be in the future.

The transparent and collaborative nature of the process helps build trust, engagement and commitment to the project.

The number of workshops required will depend on the size and geography of the client organisation. As a guide, workshop groups should be limited to a maximum of 20 participants. Workshops may be run simultaneously over a short period or staged over several weeks.

Overview
Each workshop lasts half a day and consists of a presentation followed by three exercises.

Approximately three weeks before the workshop, participants should receive an invitation explaining the purpose of the project, workshop logistics and preparation instructions for Exercise 1.

Presentation (10 minutes)
The presentation should have the energy of a TED-style keynote: informative, engaging and thought-provoking. Its purpose is not to persuade, but to provide context, establish understanding and encourage participation.

Cover:
- Introductions.
- What is changing in the world and why.
- The power and potential of SOI®.
- The project process.

- A short Q&A to confirm understanding.

Outputs
- Participants understand the drivers of change affecting organisations today.
- Participants understand the value of SOI® and the importance of the project.

Exercise 1
Timing: Depends on group size
Prior to the workshop, participants are asked to bring two objects (or photographs of them). The first should represent how they perceive the organisation today; the second should represent what they believe it should become in the future.

Each participant is given two minutes to explain their choices. The facilitator records key themes under the headings *Today* and *Tomorrow*.

Debate should be kept to a minimum. The objective is to capture individual perspectives without challenge or interruption.

Outputs
• Insight into how participants currently perceive the organisation.
• Insight into future aspirations.
• Understanding of the gap between today's reality and tomorrow's ambition.
• Understanding of the diversity of opinion and the extent to which a shared purpose already exists.
Photographs of participants presenting their objects can be useful for later project communications and for reinforcing the value of collaboration.

Exercise 2
Timing: 90 minutes
Participants are divided into teams. Each team nominates a leader and receives a deck of image cards and a worksheet. The cards include animals, shapes, modes of transport and abstract images.

Teams complete two tasks:

I. Select images that best represent the qualities of the organisation today. The associated qualities are recorded under *Actual Qualities*.
II. Repeat the process, selecting images that represent the qualities the organisation will need to ensure it is fit for the future. These are recorded under *Ideal Qualities*.

Teams then present their findings to the wider group. The facilitator records the qualities and themes on a flip chart or whiteboard. Results from all workshops should be consolidated and compared to identify patterns and recurring themes.

Outputs
- Insight into how teams perceive the organisation today and in the future.
- Identification of existing and aspirational qualities.

2.2 WORKSHOPS (cont.)

- Understanding of the gap between actual and desired positioning.
- Indication of the degree to which a shared purpose exists.

Exercise 3
Timing: 60 minutes
Participants return to their teams. Each team receives a worksheet containing 20 tangible qualities and 20 intangible qualities. These should be drawn from the desk research, benchmarking and interview phases. Four blank spaces are provided for additional suggestions.

Teams are asked to identify four tangible qualities and four intangible qualities they believe the organisation will need to ensure it is fit for the future.

The group is then brought back together. Each quality is discussed and assessed according to the extent to which it is already displayed by the organisation:

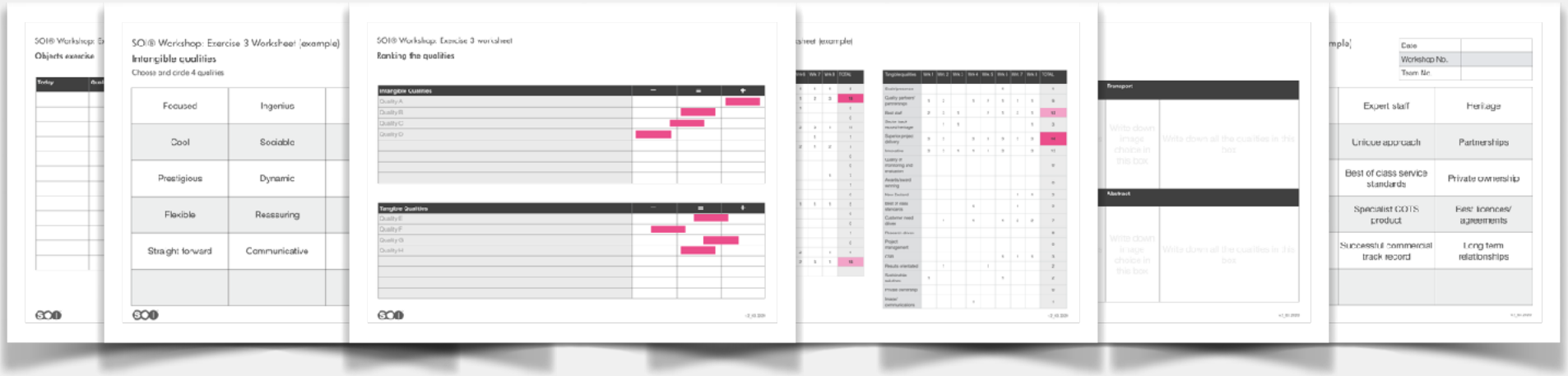
Positive (+) – The organisation displays this quality.

Neutral (=) – The organisation displays this quality to some extent.

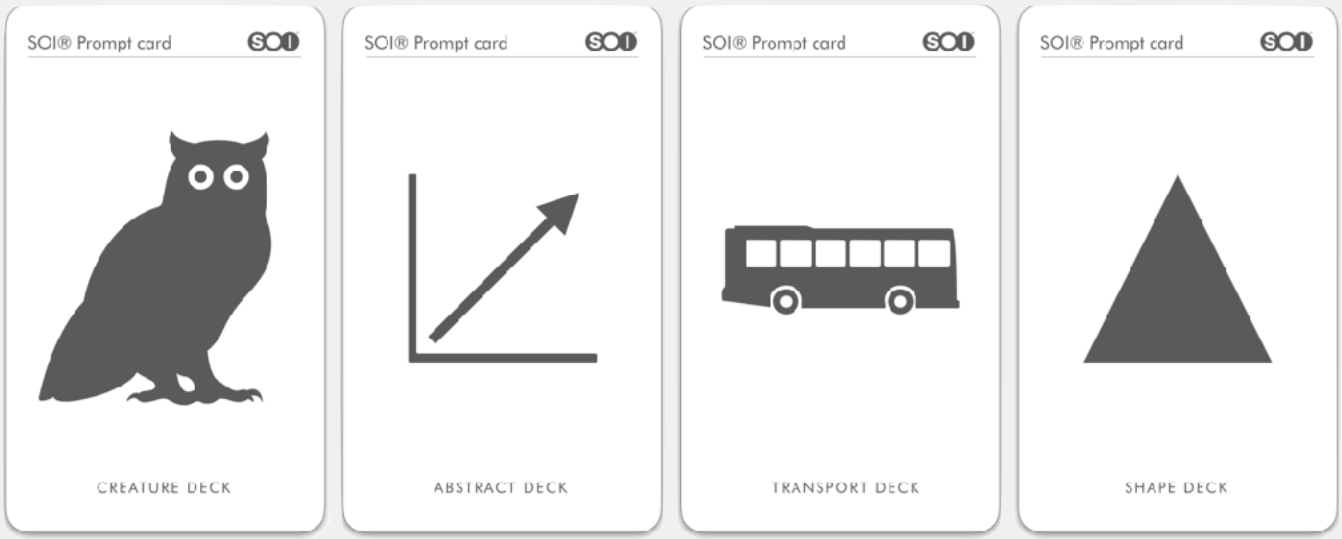
Negative (-) – The organisation does not display this quality.

Outputs
- Insight into how participants perceive the organisation today and in the future.
- Identification of key organisational qualities.
- Understanding of current positioning.
- Indication of differences in opinion.
- Insight into the depth of knowledge within the group.

For Associates, the real value of the workshops lies not in the individual exercises but in the patterns that emerge across them. Pay particular attention to recurring themes, unexpected insights, points of consensus and areas of tension. These often provide the strongest clues as to the organisation's latent purpose, future direction and potential SOI®.


SOI® Workshop: Exercise 3 Worksheet (example)
Intangible qualities
Choose and circle 4 qualities
Focused
Ingenius
Cool
Sociable
Prestigious
Dynamic
Flexible
Reassuring
Straight forward
Communicative
SOI® Workshop: Exercise 3 worksheet
Ranking the qualities
Transport
Write down / image choice in this box
Write down all the qualities in this box
Abstract
Write down / image choice in this box
Write down all the qualities in this box
Expert staff
Heritage
Unique approach
Partnerships
Best of class service standards
Private ownership
Specialist COTS product
Easy licences/ agreements
Successful commercial track record
Long term relationships


SOI® Workshop
Prompt cards


SOI® Prompt card
CREATURE DECK
SOI® Prompt card
ABSTRACT DECK
SOI® Prompt card
TRANSPORT DECK
SOI® Prompt card
SHAPE DECK

2.3 INTERVIEWS

Interviews are gold dust.

Held in confidence, they are one of the most valuable elements of the SOI® research phase. More than any other tool, they help uncover what the client organisation is truly about, revealing the motivations, aspirations, concerns and beliefs that shape its culture and future direction.

This part of the process should not be delegated internally. To gain genuine insight, interviewees must feel able to speak openly to someone independent and skilled in asking thoughtful questions and listening carefully to the answers.

A broad mix of internal and external interviewees should be selected, including decision-makers, opinion formers and key stakeholders. Interviews should be conducted in a logical sequence, allowing insights from one conversation to inform the next.

Interviews are not surveys. Each discussion should be tailored to the individual and evolve as the project progresses. In many cases, three or four well-chosen questions are enough to generate a rich and valuable conversation.

As well as gathering facts, stories and perspectives, interviews provide an opportunity to test emerging ideas, identify potential barriers to change and assess support for future directions.

AI-powered transcription tools can reduce administration time and help identify recurring themes. However, insight comes from interpretation, judgement and the connections that emerge between conversations.

As with workshops, invitations and follow-up communications should be used to build engagement, maintain momentum and reinforce the collaborative nature of the SOI® process.

Interview questions

1. Background

1.1 What has made the business successful to date?
1.2 What is the reputation of the business – would you say it is positive, negative, or neutral? Does it vary for different stakeholders?
1.3 How is the reputation of the business managed? How do you think it should be managed?
1.4 What role do values play (amongst employees, leadership, stakeholders)?
1.5 How would you describe the leadership style of the business; how do things get done?
1.5 Are successes celebrated; what ones, when and how?
1.6 Is there pride in the business; what is the basis for it?

2. Sector
2.1 What is the reputation of the sector?
2.2 What is the future for the sector; to what degree will the sector change; how will the sector develop?
2.3 Who/what is influencing that change?
2.4 Who are the opinion formers/ leaders within the sector?
2.5 What factors do companies in the sector compete on?

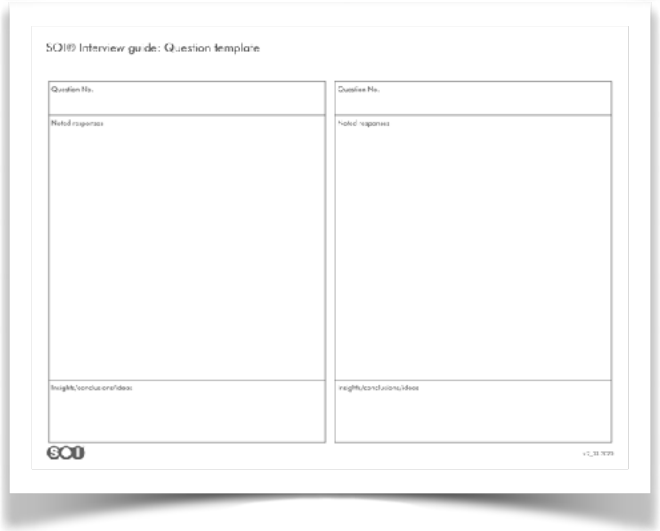
3. Positioning
3.1 How is the business currently positioned? Has that always been the case? How should it be positioned in the future – the same/differently?
3.2 Who do you regard as your most immediate competitors? How are the top three positioned; what are their strengths/weaknesses?
3.4 Does the business ever collaborate with its competitors; how?
3.5 What are the preferences and expectations of your customers (stakeholders)?
3.6 How are the preferences/ideals or your customers (stakeholders), changing and developing?
3.7 How do you rank your stakeholders; who are the most important? which have the greatest influence on your business?

4. Future
4.1 What is the ambition of the business?
4.2 How will the business measure success in the future?
4.3 What are the critical factors that will affect the business' performance in the future?
4.4 What organisations do you most admire in the sector?
4.5 What organisations do you most admire outside the sector and why?

5. And finally...
5.1 Is there anything that I haven't asked you that you feel is important for me to know?


SOI® Interview guide

Project/program | Interview date/time
Name | Job title
Job description | Length of service
Department | Reports to
Previous experience | External interests
Preliminaries


SOI® Interview guide: Question template

Question No. | Question No.
Noted responses | Noted responses
Insight/conclusions/ideas | Insight/conclusions/ideas

2.4 UNDERSTANDING STAKEHOLDERS

An article published by the *Financial Times* once defined a stakeholder as "anyone who can bugger up your business."

While tongue-in-cheek, the observation contains an important truth.

Understanding stakeholder perceptions, expectations and concerns is essential to identifying a meaningful SOI®. Without understanding what stakeholders need, value and care about, an organisation cannot align itself around an idea that matters to them.

Stakeholders exist both inside and outside the client organisation. Together, they form the ecosystem within which it operates.

There are two broad categories of stakeholder:

Primary stakeholders have a direct interest in the organisation and are affected by its success or failure. They typically include owners, employees, customers, investors, suppliers, partners, contractors, governments and local communities.

Secondary stakeholders have an indirect relationship with the organisation but can still influence, or be influenced by, its actions. They may include regulators, trade associations, NGOs, advocacy groups, competitors, media, analysts, researchers, educational institutions and the wider public.

The number and variety of stakeholders can be surprising. Increasingly, organisations must also recognise their dependence on the natural environment.

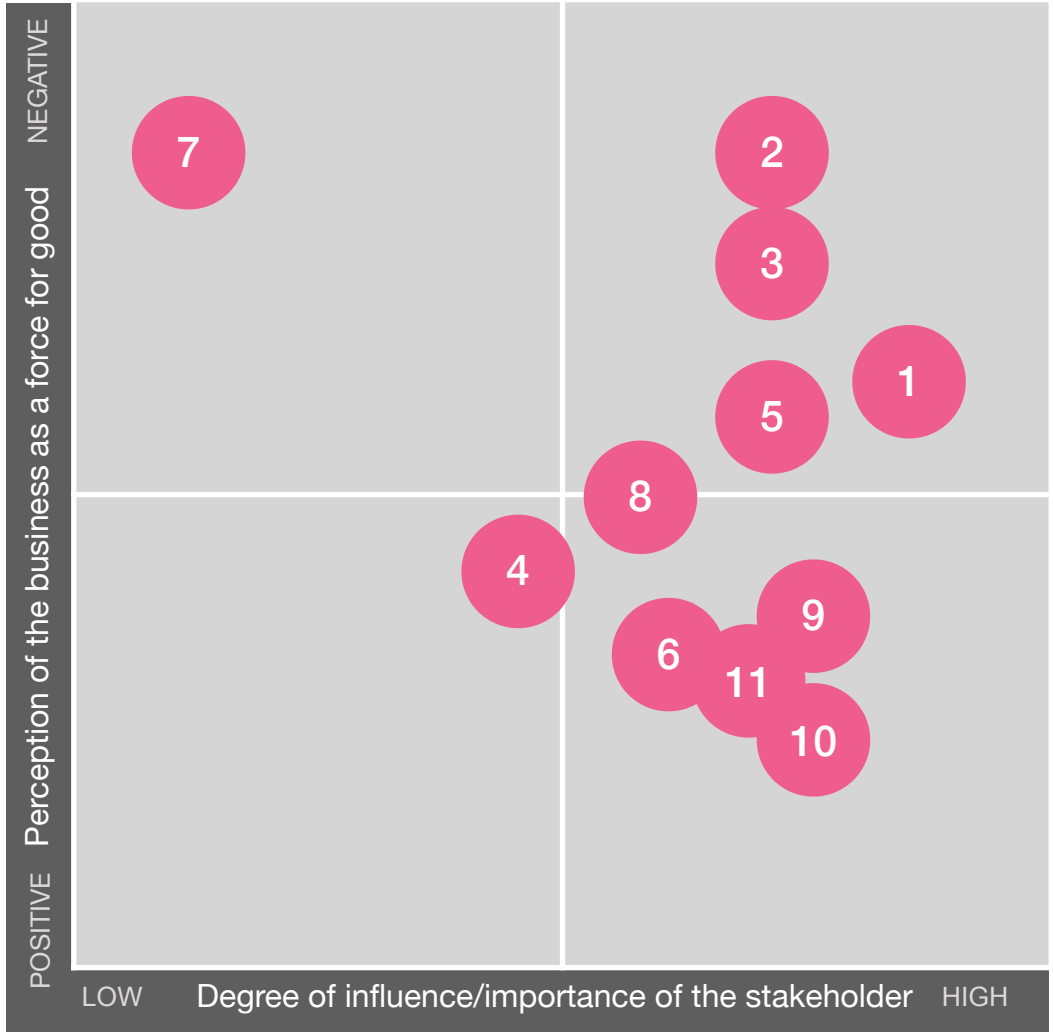
While it may not have a voice of its own, the health of the planet can have a profound influence on organisational performance and long-term success. Stakeholders form opinions through direct experience, organisational communications and the views of others.

In a connected world, perceptions can spread quickly and influence behaviour long before all the facts are known. Understanding those perceptions is therefore just as important as understanding reality itself.

Bringing together a diverse group of stakeholders to explore their views, concerns and influence can generate valuable insights, build goodwill and help shape the SOI®.

The stakeholder mapping exercise opposite is based on three simple questions:

- Who are our stakeholders?
- How do they perceive the organisation as a force for good?
- What are their concerns?



Identified stakeholder groups

1. Customers
2. Staff
3. Shareholders
4. Suppliers
5. Competitors
6. Media
7. NGOs
8. Associations
9. Sector think tanks
10. Policy makers/regulators
11. Government watchdogs

The first part of the exercise is to brainstorm all the stakeholders you can think of. This example shows a very short list of top-line stakeholder groups. Each of these groups can be broken down into types and then individual organisations. For instance, there are lots of types of media. You could easily identify 30+ stakeholders in a brainstorming session.

2.5 POSITIONING SPECTRUM

When marketing pioneer Walter Landor stated in the 1960s that "Products are made in the factory, but brands are created in the mind," he captured in one sentence the potency of positioning. Understanding the position an organisation, and others within its ecosystem, occupy in the minds of key stakeholders is an important step toward creating a credible and successful SOI®.

While traditional businesses use positioning to gain competitive advantage, maximise sales and increase consumption, the purpose of this work is different. The objective is to help organisations, and the stakeholders that support them, thrive and prosper.

This means that while the approach to understanding positioning is similar, the goal of the exercise is fundamentally different. The point of an SOI® is to gather people and resources around an idea that will make a positive difference in the world. Identifying which competitors and suppliers are already positioned to do this, and how they reinforce that position through their communications and actions, can generate insights, ideas and future partnership opportunities.

Mapping

The positioning spectrum, illustrated on the opposite page, helps visualise where key stakeholders sit relative to the client organisation. To populate it:

- Decide which external stakeholders should be reviewed.
- Identify and analyse their communications.

The analysis is a two-step process that begins with stakeholder websites.

Step 1

Proposition

Usually found in the 'About Us' section. It may be immediately clear, or require reviewing purpose, mission and vision statements to determine what is being communicated and whether it is consistent.

Marketing strap-line

Often linked to the logo. Effective strap-lines summarise the organisation's purpose in a few memorable words.

Key messages

These are the reasons to believe in the organisation and its offers. Effective organisations repeat them consistently across websites and communication channels.

Qualities

Tangible qualities (what an organisation delivers) and intangible qualities (the experience it creates) require some skill to identify. Recurring themes will emerge through value propositions, promises and commitments.

Organisations with clarity tend to focus on a small number of qualities. Those that do not often rely on extensive lists in the hope of covering every possibility.

Step 2

Compare the look and feel, and tone of voice, of the organisations being reviewed;

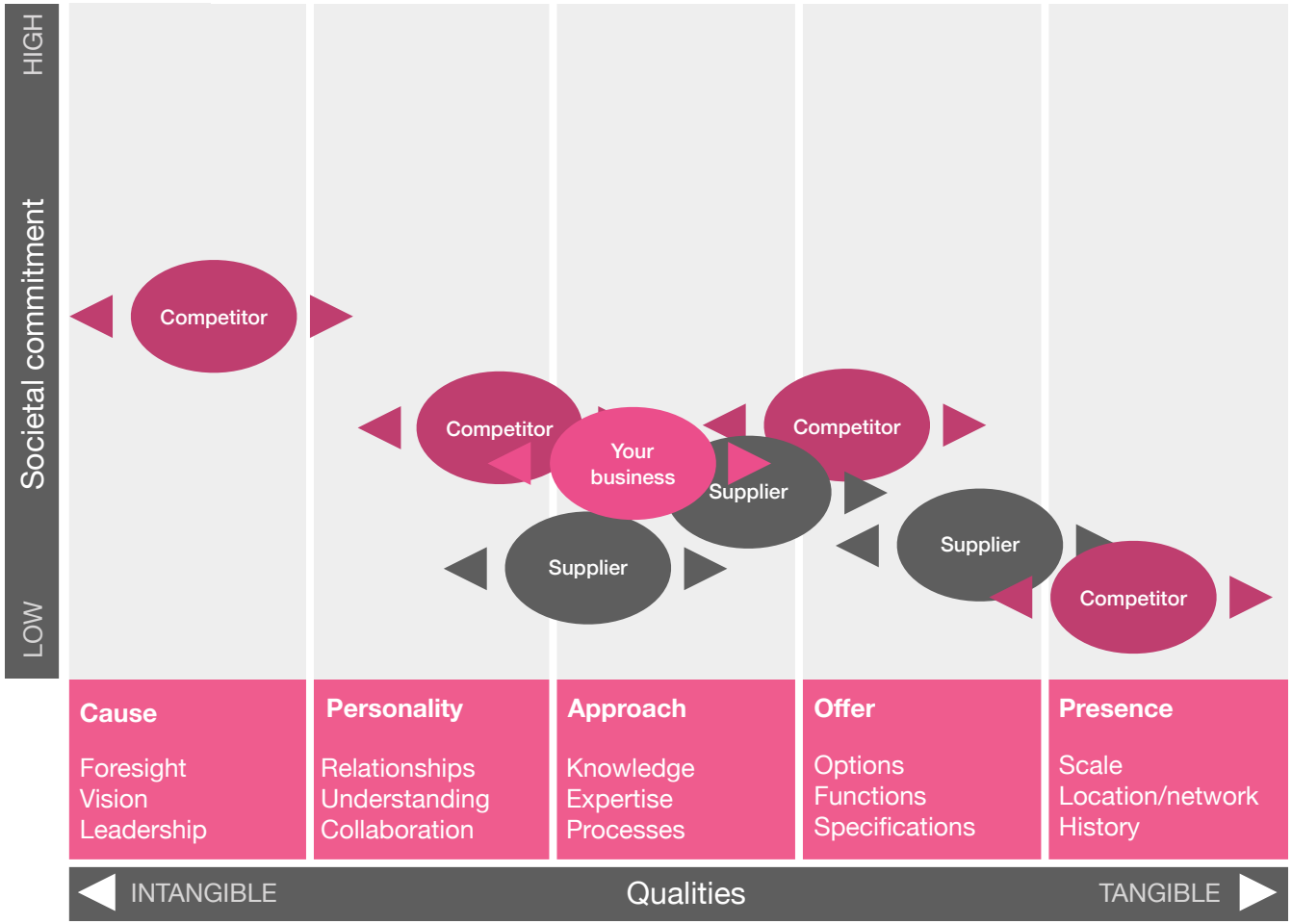
in essence, their communicated personality.

Evaluate each against best-practice criteria such as appeal, distinctiveness, memorability, engagement, simplicity, effectiveness, consistency, cost efficiency and adaptability across media channels.

Apply a score against each criterion:

- Negative: 1–3
  - Neutral: 4–7
  - Positive: 8–10

The same analysis should be carried out on the client organisation. The resulting information will help map relative positioning, identify what is working and what is not, and reveal opportunities to collaborate, strengthen stakeholder relationships and support the wider ecosystem in which the organisation operates.



Organisations on the right of the spectrum quote tangible qualities, such as how big they are, how many things they sell, and what the things they sell do in their communications. Organisations on the left quote intangible qualities that explain why they do what they do. Many organisations today claim to be making some sort of contribution to society. The likely impact of that contribution can also be mapped on this spectrum once you have carried out the social contribution analysis explained in the next chapter.

2.6 SOCIAL CONTRIBUTION ANALYSIS

Reviewing how a client organisation already contributes to society is a simple exercise that can generate valuable insights and help identify its SOI®.

Many organisations support social, environmental or community initiatives in some form. These activities may range from charitable giving and volunteering through to sustainability programmes, responsible business practices and initiatives that create value for both the organisation and society.

Understanding the nature, purpose and impact of these activities helps reveal stakeholder priorities, organisational values and existing strengths that may inform the development of the SOI®.

This exercise also helps distinguish between activities that sit on the periphery of the organisation and those that are beginning to influence strategy, culture and decision-making.

Step 1
Identify all current social, environmental and community-related initiatives.
Gather relevant documents and, where necessary, conduct interviews with key individuals inside and outside the organisation to build a complete picture.

Step 2
Use the Social Contribution Working Sheet to capture the purpose, costs, business impact and societal impact associated with each initiative.

Step 3
Use the Social Contribution Summary Sheet to compare, rank and evaluate the effectiveness of all current activities.
Look for patterns, strengths, overlaps and gaps. Which activities create the greatest value? Which are most closely aligned to stakeholder expectations? Which support the organisation's long-term direction?
The objective is not simply to catalogue activities, but to understand what they reveal about the organisation and the role it seeks to play in the wider world.
The resulting insights will help identify potential SOI® themes and provide a foundation for refining future investments, partnerships and strategic priorities.

AI can assist by organising large volumes of information, identifying themes and comparing initiatives against stakeholder priorities. However, assessing the significance and strategic relevance of those activities remains a human judgement.

Charity	Philanthropy	Corporate Social Responsibility	Shared Value	Sustainability
Simple acts of kindness (Giving fish)	Charity with direction (Teaching how to fish)	Actions that minimise harm (Not overfishing)	Identifying societal problems that realise a return on investment for the business	Actions that assure the resilience of the business and society
Short-term Emotional intervention Focused on providing relief	Mid/long-term Focused on problem solving Cause-driven	Compliance with standards largely set by external agencies Responsible citizenship Triple bottom line reporting Building trust Protecting brand reputation 'Bolt-on' initiatives	Focus on profitability Transactional relationships pursued by some functions of the business Achieving competitive advantage Lowering costs Driving efficiencies and addressing deficiencies	Optimizing total alignment across all functions of the business to achieve a common ideal Building effective ecosystem relationships Innovation that meets the needs of all stakeholders Reducing risk for all **Core SOI® strategy**

Having an SOI® at the core of your business sits squarely in the sustainability category.

2.7 TOUCH-POINT ANALYSIS

Touch-points are the moments when stakeholders experience the client organisation directly. They are the points at which expectations are either confirmed or challenged, and where perceptions are formed, reinforced or damaged.

Every stakeholder group experiences the organisation through a series of touch-points. For customers these may include marketing, sales interactions, service delivery and support. For employees they may include recruitment, onboarding, leadership behaviours, internal communications, systems, meetings and workplace culture.

Analysing these touch-points helps identify where the organisation creates value, where friction exists and where stakeholder experiences are inconsistent with its aspirations. It also reveals opportunities to improve alignment, efficiency and impact.

The Process

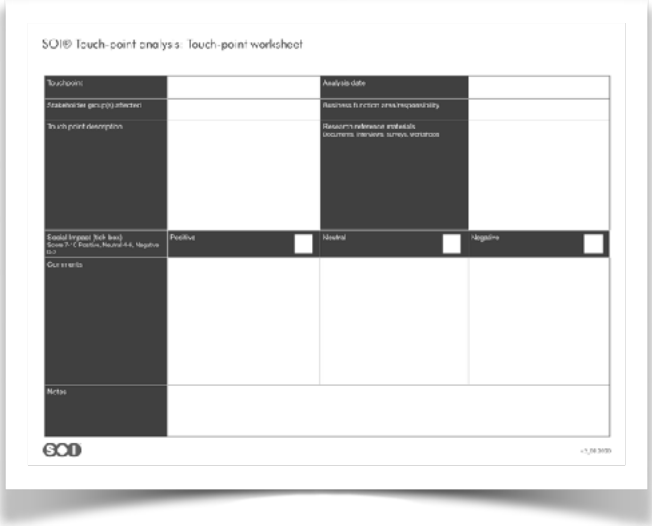
Using the SOI® Touch-point Dashboard, work with representatives from different business functions to:

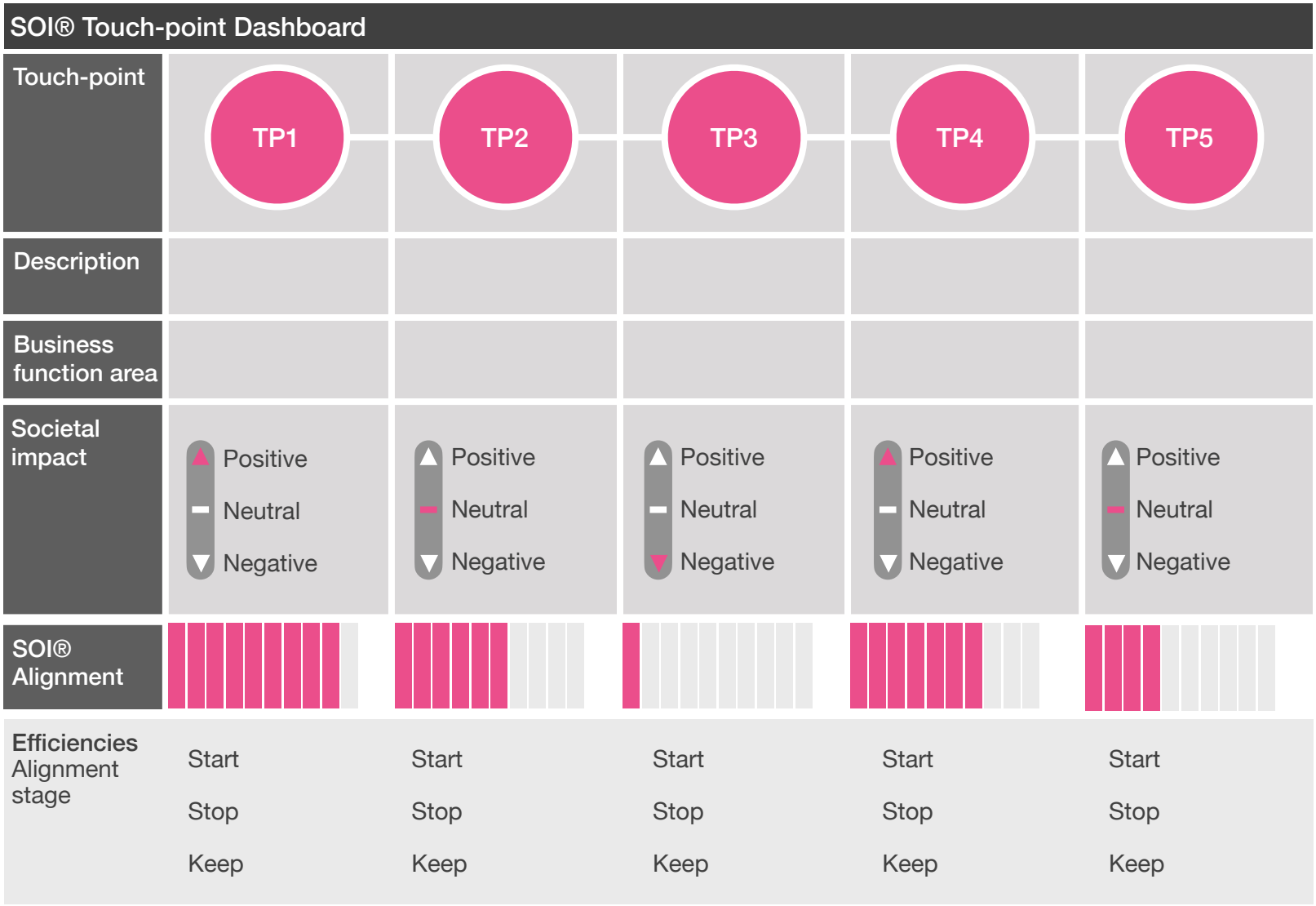
- Identify key stakeholder touch-points.
- Describe the experience currently being delivered.
- Assess whether the experience is positive, neutral or negative.
- Consider the societal and organisational impact of each touch-point.
- Identify opportunities to start, stop or improve activities.
- Prioritise areas requiring attention.

Where possible, validate findings directly with stakeholders rather than relying solely on internal assumptions.

This exercise is completed before the SOI® is defined, but its value extends well beyond the Identify phase. The resulting insights provide a practical foundation for future alignment work, helping the client organisation focus effort where it will have the greatest impact.

Well-executed touch-point analysis often uncovers opportunities to improve stakeholder experience, strengthen culture, increase efficiency and reduce unnecessary cost.




SOI® Touch-point Dashboard
Touch-point
TP1
TP2
TP3
TP4
TP5
Description
Business function area
Societal impact
Positive
Neutral
Negative
SOI® Alignment
Efficiencies Alignment stage
Start
Stop
Keep

2.8 COLLECTIVE INSIGHT

Engagement is essential to identifying a credible and meaningful SOI®. However, it is rarely practical to interview every stakeholder or involve everyone in workshops.

Collective Insight provides a scalable way to gather perspectives, test assumptions and involve larger groups of people in the process. It helps ensure that important voices are not overlooked and enables the knowledge, experience and ideas of stakeholders to be captured and analysed.

Today, this can take many forms, including online workshops, surveys, collaborative platforms, discussion forums, digital whiteboards and AI-supported engagement tools.

The objective is not simply to gather more data, but to uncover patterns, priorities and opportunities that may otherwise remain hidden.

A particular advantage of digital engagement is that it often encourages more open and honest participation.

People are frequently willing to share views and ideas that they may be reluctant to express in traditional organisational settings.

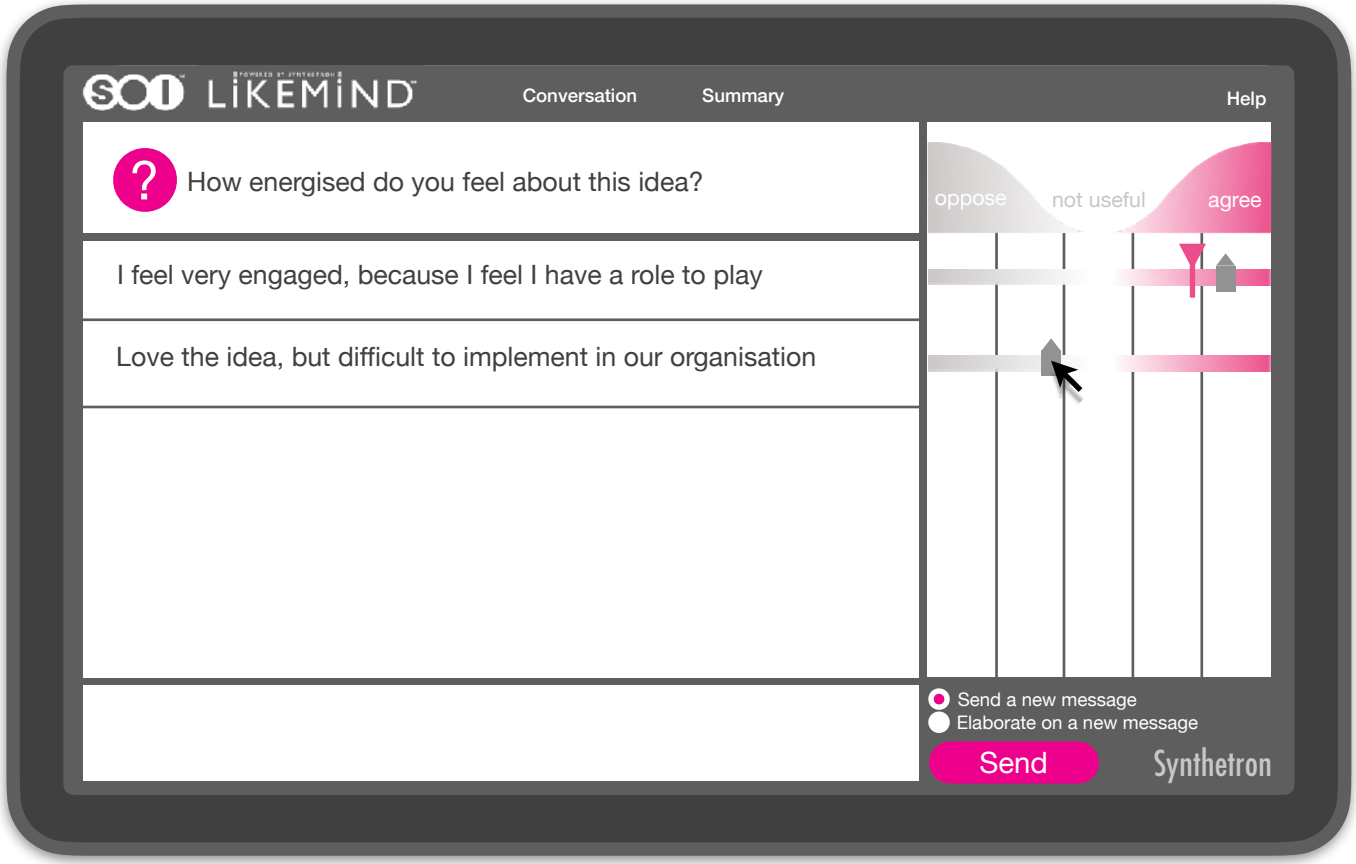
The Process

- Identify the stakeholder groups you wish to engage.
- Select the most appropriate engagement platform or method.
- Determine whether participation should be mixed or targeted by stakeholder group.
- Develop a focused set of questions that address gaps in understanding or test emerging themes.
- Facilitate the process in a way that encourages participation, openness and constructive challenge.
- Analyse the results to identify recurring themes, priorities, concerns and opportunities.

AI can be particularly useful in helping to synthesise large volumes of feedback, identify recurring themes and highlight areas of consensus or disagreement. However, interpretation and judgement remain the responsibility of the Associate.

The value of Collective Insight lies not only in the quality of the insights generated but also in the sense of involvement it creates. When stakeholders feel heard, they are more likely to support the outcomes that emerge.

Used well, Collective Insight can accelerate learning, strengthen engagement and provide valuable evidence to support the development of a robust SOI®.



Platforms such as Synthetron pioneered the ability to gather and prioritise stakeholder ideas and opinions from large groups. Today, a combination of digital engagement tools and AI can help organisations capture, analyse and synthesise stakeholder feedback more efficiently than ever.

2.9 BRINGING IT ALL TOGETHER

By this stage of the process, you will have gathered a significant amount of information from research, interviews, workshops, stakeholder analysis, positioning reviews, touch-point analysis and other sources.

The challenge is no longer collecting information. It is making sense of it.

The objective is to bring all findings together into a single, coherent narrative that explains where the client organisation is today, what forces are shaping its future and what opportunities exist to create greater value for both the organisation and society.

This is best achieved through the development of a hypothesis presentation. The role of the presentation is to organise the evidence, identify recurring themes, draw out key insights and prepare the ground for defining the SOI®.

A good hypothesis presentation does more than report findings. It explains what the evidence means, highlights the choices available and recommends a direction of travel.

Creating the presentation is often one of the most demanding parts of the Identify phase. Gathering information is relatively straightforward; synthesising it into a logical and compelling story requires judgement, critical thinking and experience.

AI can be helpful in organising information, identifying patterns and summarising large volumes of data. However, interpretation, prioritisation and strategic recommendation remain the responsibility of the Associate.

The presentation should be delivered to the leadership team and other key stakeholders with sufficient time for discussion and challenge. This is an important moment in the project. It provides an opportunity to build understanding, generate commitment and create confidence in the work that follows.

The output from the Identify phase should be a clear view of:

- Where the organisation is today.
- How stakeholders perceive it.
- The forces likely to shape its future.
- The opportunities and challenges it faces.
- The themes that point towards a credible SOI®.

With this foundation in place, the process moves from identifying the SOI® to defining it.

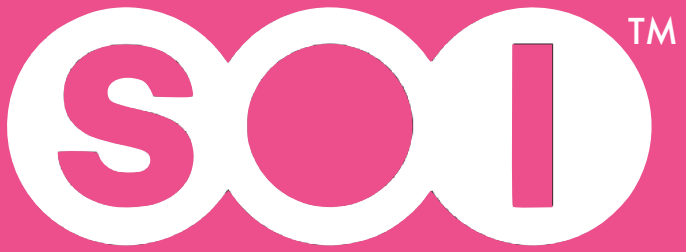
SOI® PRESENTATION	**Title slide** Project code name Date	**Objectives** Why	**Contents** Section 1 Section 2 Section 3	**SOI®** Methodology		
Section 1 IDENTIFYING Research and analysis	**Section Introduction** Explanation Scope Objectives	**Desk Research** Approach Scope Insights	**Stakeholder Analysis** Approach Scope Insights	**Social Contribution Analysis** Approach Scope Insights	**Workshops** Approach Scope Insights	**Touch-Point Analysis** Approach Scope Insights
	Crowdsourcing Approach Scope Insights	**Interviews** Approach Scope Insights	**Research Conclusion** Key insights			
	Positioning Explanation Scope Objectives	**Positioning analysis** Stakeholders	**Positioning analysis** Your business today	**Positioning options** Today v tomorrow	**Positioning recommendation** Fit for future position	
Section 2 DEFINING Values Positioning statement SOI®	**Section Introduction** Explanation Objective	**Positioning statement** Solution	**Value 1** Solution	**Value 2** Solution	**Value 3** Solution	**Value 4** Solution
	Single Organizing Idea Solution	**SOI® Strategic Framework** Solution	**Summary** Conclusions Benefits	**Stress Testing** Instructions		
Section 3 ALIGNING Next steps	**Section Introduction** Explanation Objective	**Next steps** Explanation Deliverables	**Roadmap** Explanation	**Presentation summary** Key points		

It's best to present the research work together with the SOI® Startegic Framework. This means one single presentation rather than two.

KEY POINTS

- Effective SOI®s are discovered through a combination of research, stakeholder engagement, analysis and informed judgement.
- Workshops, interviews and stakeholder engagement help uncover the values, aspirations, perceptions and motivations that shape the client organisation.
- Understanding the gap between how stakeholders perceive the organisation today and how they would like it to be perceived in the future helps identify opportunities for change and growth.
- Research and analysis should focus not only on the client organisation itself, but also on the wider ecosystem in which it operates, including stakeholders, competitors, technology, society and the environment.
- The purpose of the Identify phase is to synthesise evidence into clear insights that provide a credible foundation for defining the organisation's SOI®.

YOUR NOTES



SINGLE

ORGANIZING

IDEA

3.0

45-58

DEFINE

How to transform research and insight into a clear, practical and enduring strategic framework.

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3.2 POSITIONING STATEMENT 49

3.3 CORE VALUES 51

3.4 SINGLE ORGANIZING IDEA SOI® 53

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3.1 THE SOI® STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK

Many organisations invest significant time and money creating strategies, only for them to end up forgotten in presentations, reports and filing systems while attention shifts back to day-to-day priorities.

Yet strategy matters. Without clarity of direction, organisations drift.

The SOI® Strategic Framework is the core strategic output of the Define phase. It brings together three elements:

- Positioning Statement
- Values
- Single Organizing Idea

Together, these explain the why, what and how of the client organisation.

The framework provides a single-minded focus for decision-making, alignment and measurement. It defines what the organisation is seeking to achieve, the principles that guide behaviour and the idea around which people, resources and effort will be organised.

Unlike many strategy documents, the SOI® Strategic Framework is designed to be visible, accessible and widely understood.

It is a practical communication tool that helps stakeholders understand what the organisation is doing, why it matters and how they can contribute.

Everything learned during the Identify phase is now distilled into three simple but powerful components. The challenge is not creating more complexity; it is creating greater clarity.

The words chosen for each element matter. They will influence strategy, culture, governance, decision-making and stakeholder relationships for years to come.

Get this right and the extensive research, analysis and engagement undertaken during the Identify phase will be transformed into a practical framework capable of guiding the organisation's future direction and measuring its progress.

SOI® Strategic Framework		
POSITIONING STATEMENT	CORE VALUES	SINGLE ORGANIZING IDEA
Your elevator pitch	Your commitments	Your guiding star
The positioning statement frames and explains the value of your SOI® to your business and to society in two or three pithy sentences. It's your elevator pitch.	Identified through research, these values underpin your SOI®. Each value is a commitment against which actions and ideas can be assessed and monitored. They are carefully selected to help ensure holistic and consistent alignment of your enterprise with the SOI®.	An SOI® is a simple and memorable call to action that is measured. Relevant, compelling and sustainable, an SOI® succinctly captures the core purpose of your enterprise. It's your guiding star.

3.2 CORE VALUES

There are no hard and fast rules when it comes to defining the three elements of the SOI® Strategic Framework. In practice, the process involves drafting, refining and testing all three elements simultaneously until they work together as a coherent whole.

That said, my recommendation is to start with the values.

Values are often described as beliefs, aspirations or cultural attributes. Within the SOI® methodology, they serve a more practical purpose. Values are the commitments that guide the actions, behaviours and attitudes required to deliver the SOI®. They are the foundations upon which the SOI® rests.

During the Identify phase, you will have gathered extensive insight from workshops, interviews, stakeholder engagement and research. Those activities will have highlighted qualities, behaviours and themes that stakeholders believe are important to the future success of the client organisation.

While this input is valuable, values should not simply be a reflection of popular opinion. Ultimately, they must represent the commitments that leadership is prepared to make in order to achieve the SOI® and create the desired future.

Core values provide a constant reference point for decision-making, leadership, performance and accountability. They help define how things get done and establish the standards against which behaviours are encouraged, recognised and rewarded.

For this reason, each value should be expressed in a way that is clear, practical and actionable. Avoid vague or generic language. The strongest values are those that directly support the delivery of the SOI® and can be translated into everyday behaviours across the organisation.

Be guided by the evidence gathered during the Identify phase, but remain focused on defining a set of values that will help turn the SOI® into reality.

The final step is to test whether the values are robust, distinctive and capable of supporting the SOI® over the long term.

Positioning statement	Core values	Single Organizing Idea
Our success is borne out of belief, a history of partnering and an understanding of what matters, and what doesn't. By being bold enough to dare and willing to care we help make everyone feel like winners.	**Cooperative** Our heritage shows that we get the best results when we work in solidarity. By being inclusive we unite and support joint efforts that enhance our collective strength. **Accountable** Our success is determined by the standards we set, the outcomes we pursue and the responsibility we take. By being straightforward, fair and answerable we underline we are dependable. **Attentive** By being tenacious, by having the confidence to open our minds and empathise, we create unique opportunities that allow compassion and understanding to push forward progress. **Courageous** Achieving better takes audacity and commitment. By relentlessly looking for improvement we challenge the status quo and shape new solutions and efficiencies.	Feel-good

This Strategic Framework example is based on a global sports-inspired fashion business with a century-long history. Research revealed that customers, employees and suppliers increasingly wanted purchasing decisions and business practices to reflect genuine social value, not just style or CSR claims. The opportunity was to turn 'feeling good' into a simple but powerful purpose capable of guiding the entire business towards a successful, sustainable future.

3.3 POSITIONING STATEMENT

The Positioning Statement is a concise explanation of why the SOI® matters to the organisation, its stakeholders and society.

It is not a sales pitch, a slogan or a purpose statement. Nor is it an aspiration or a declaration of intent. It is a statement of fact that explains the role the organisation plays, the value it creates and the difference it seeks to make.

A strong Positioning Statement should be expressed in two or three short sentences that anyone can understand and remember.

To be effective it should be:

Short
People rarely have the time or inclination to absorb lengthy explanations. A concise statement is more likely to be understood, remembered and shared.

Direct
Avoid jargon, complexity and unnecessary language. The statement should be clear, confident and easy to understand.

Inspiring
While it is not intended to sell, it should communicate why the organisation matters and why its contribution is important. It should leave people with a sense of purpose, relevance and possibility.

Practical
The Positioning Statement should provide clarity and direction. It should help stakeholders understand what the organisation stands for and support decision-making throughout the business.

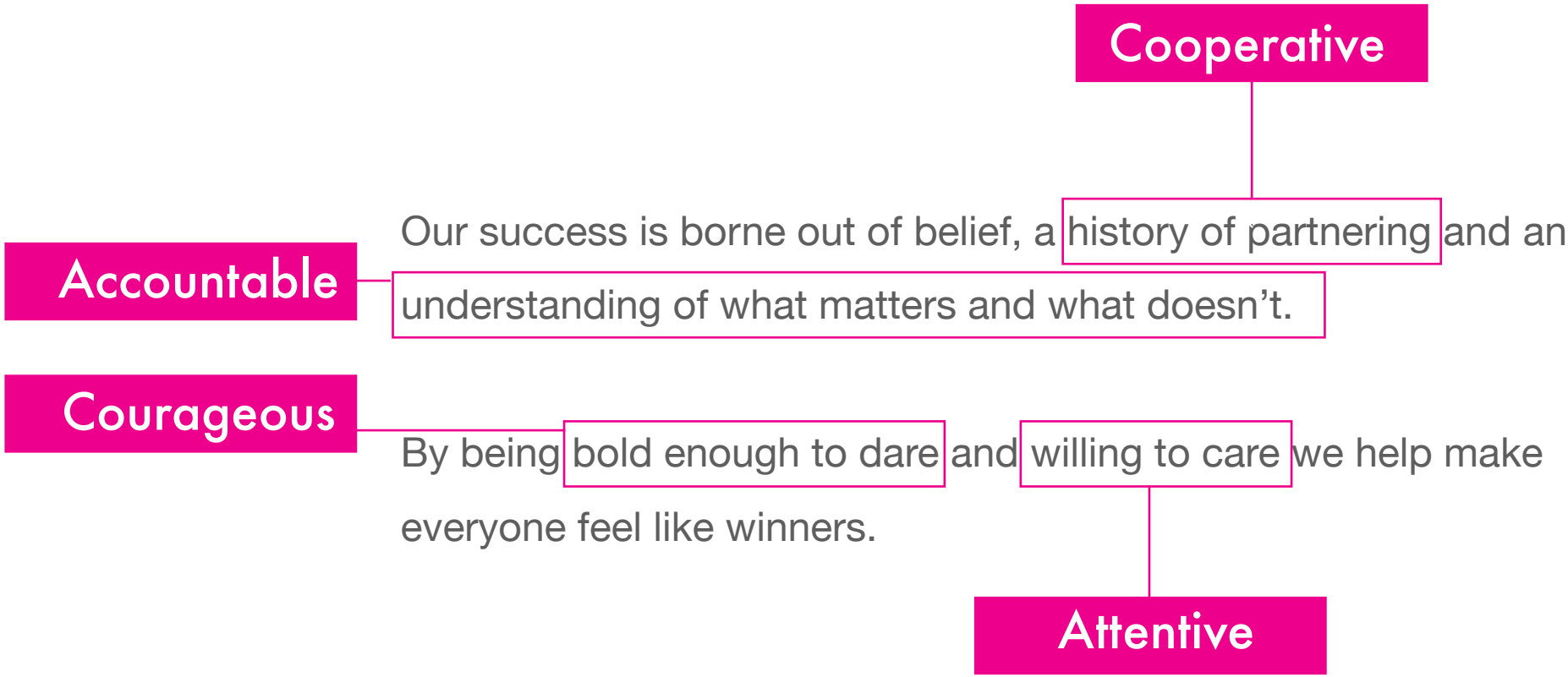
Genuine
The strongest Positioning Statements emerge from evidence, insight and truth.

They reflect the reality of the organisation and the commitments it is prepared to make. Authenticity matters because organisations are ultimately judged by what they do rather than what they say.

Like the values and the SOI®, developing a strong Positioning Statement is an iterative process. Expect to draft, test, refine and redraft until the words accurately capture the essence of the organisation and the role it seeks to play in the world.

When the Positioning Statement, Values and SOI® work together as a coherent whole, the foundation of the SOI® Strategic Framework is in place.

The positioning statement is based on the identified core values and SOI®. Weaving them together will help form the two or three sentences needed to explain the value and relevance of the organisation.



3.4 SINGLE ORGANIZING IDEA (SOI®)

The Single Organizing Idea® is the central idea around which the client organisation is aligned.

It is the unifying concept that guides decisions, shapes priorities and provides a shared sense of direction. At its best, the SOI® becomes a constant reference point for leadership, governance, culture, innovation, communication and performance.

Defining an SOI® can be straightforward or intensely challenging.

Sometimes an idea emerges naturally during the Identify phase. A recurring phrase, powerful insight or common theme may repeatedly surface through interviews, workshops and stakeholder engagement. On other occasions, the process requires extensive discussion, testing and refinement before the right idea emerges.

The simplicity of an SOI® can be deceptive. The challenge is often not finding more words, but finding fewer.

Some SOI®s can be expressed in a single word. Volvo's long-standing focus on *Safety* is a well-known example. Others are expressed as a short phrase, such as *Building Better Communities, Collective Success* or *Stewarding Greater Value.*

Whatever form it takes, a strong SOI® should be distinctive, memorable, relevant, inspiring and practical. Most importantly, it should guide the actions, behaviours and decisions required to create long-term value for both the organisation and its stakeholders.

Once the Core Values, Positioning Statement and Single Organizing Idea® have been defined, the SOI® Strategic Framework is complete.

The final step is to test whether the three elements work together as a coherent whole and are robust enough to withstand future challenges.

Performance: A standard of success/achievement
Behaviour: Positive morals and ethics, kindness, fairness
Can be measured/assessed/factored

FEEL-GOOD

A human sense/emotion
Image: Quality, finish
Associated with aptitude, intuition, inclination
An outcome/reaction resulting from a connection, experience (a moment of truth)

3.5 STRESS TESTING

Once the SOI® Strategic Framework has been drafted, it is time to stress test it.

Ask members of the team to review the stress test questions individually before coming together to discuss the implications and opportunities they reveal. Encourage them to consider both the organisation as a whole and the specific areas for which they are responsible.

Remember, there is no such thing as a perfect strategy and there is no such thing as a perfect set of words. The purpose of stress testing is to determine whether the Positioning Statement, Core Values and Single Organizing Idea® are strong enough to guide the organisation into the future.

Ultimately, one question matters more than any other:

Will this SOI® help the organisation thrive while making a positive contribution to society?

If the answer is yes, the SOI® Strategic Framework is ready to move from definition to implementation.

8 POINT STRESS TEST

1. Credible
Is the SOI® based on reality, hard facts and evidence?

2. Resilient
Will the SOI® be sustainable over the long-term regardless of management, technology and market changes?

3. Relevant
Will the SOI® deliver value to our business and our stakeholders?

4. Commercial
Will alignment with the SOI® help ensure that our business thrives and maintains commercial success?

5. Beneficial
Will the adoption of the SOI® impact positively on people and the planet?

6.SINGLE
Will the SOI® provide the single-minded focus required to help separate what is important from what is not?

7. ORGANIZING
Will each function of the business and the wider ecosystem be able to self-organise their alignment and contribution to the SOI®?

8: IDEA
Is the SOI® a compelling concept that people internally and externally will admire and aspire to be a part of?

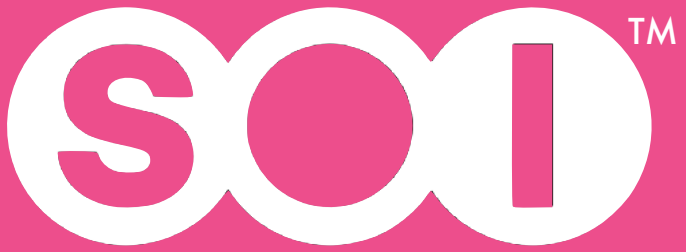
Moments of truth in our value chain. At a glance, how good (or bad) do we feel about our choices, practices and policies?							
Design	Raw materials	Fabric & yarn production	Garment production	Transport	Sales	Customers	Recycling
Choice of materials: Looks Style Quality	**Processing of raw materials:** Working conditions (time, safety, health, wages) Water usage Chemical usage	**Production of yarn and fabrics in mills:** Working conditions (time, safety, health, wages), Water usage, Chemical usage, Greenhouse gas emissions	**In our own factories, as well as our suppliers:** Working conditions (time, safety, health, wages) Environmental standards	**Transportation from factories to distribution and sales outlets:** Greenhouse gas emissions Transport types Transport distance	**Selling products:** Working conditions and environments of outlet Energy usage of stores, offices and warehouses. Data privacy for colleagues and customers, Responsible advertising Fast fashion versus sustainable fashion	**Care for clothes at home:** Energy usage/ greenhouse emissions Water usage Microfibre contamination Detergent usage	**Garment after use:** Collection Repurposing Recycling Reprocessing fibres
Feel-good?	**Feel-good?**	**Feel-good?**	**Feel-good?**	**Feel-good?**	**Feel-good?**	**Feel-good?**	**Feel-good?**

Intent alone is not enough. An effective SOI® should drive efficiencies, strengthen the value chain, improve stakeholder outcomes and create measurable impact. In this example, 'feel-good' becomes a factor that can be monitored, measured and continuously improved.

KEY POINTS

- The SOI® Strategic Framework combines three elements: Core Values, a Positioning Statement and a Single Organizing Idea®.
- Core Values are the actions, behaviours and attitudes required to deliver the SOI® and create long-term value.
- A strong Positioning Statement clearly explains the role, value and contribution of the organisation in a way that stakeholders can easily understand.
- The Single Organizing Idea® provides a shared focus that guides decision-making, alignment and performance across the organisation.
- Stress testing helps ensure the Strategic Framework is coherent, practical and capable of guiding the organisation into the future.

YOUR NOTES



SINGLE ORGANIZING IDEA

4.0

59-84

ALIGN

The tools and techniques needed to turn strategy into action and create measurable value for organisations and their stakeholders.

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4.3 SOI® ALIGNMENT CANVAS 81

4.1 TOTAL ALIGNMENT

"The future is here – it's just not evenly distributed."

William Gibson's observation is a useful reminder that ideas alone do not create change. At this stage of the SOI® process, the client organisation has identified and defined its Strategic Framework. It has a Positioning Statement, Core Values and a Single Organizing Idea®. The challenge now is turning those elements into everyday reality. This is where many strategies fail.

Organisations often invest significant time and resources creating strategy, only for it to remain trapped in presentations, reports and workshops while daily priorities continue largely unchanged. The purpose of the Align phase is to prevent that from happening.

Alignment means ensuring that decisions, behaviours, systems, communications, products, services and measures progressively move in the same direction.

The SOI® becomes more than a statement of intent. It becomes a practical reference point for how the organisation operates, allocates resources, evaluates opportunities and measures success.

For Associates, it is important to recognise that alignment is rarely achieved quickly and is never truly complete. Organisations are complex systems. Different teams, functions and stakeholders will move at different speeds. Some areas will embrace change immediately. Others will require time, support, resources and evidence before they fully commit.

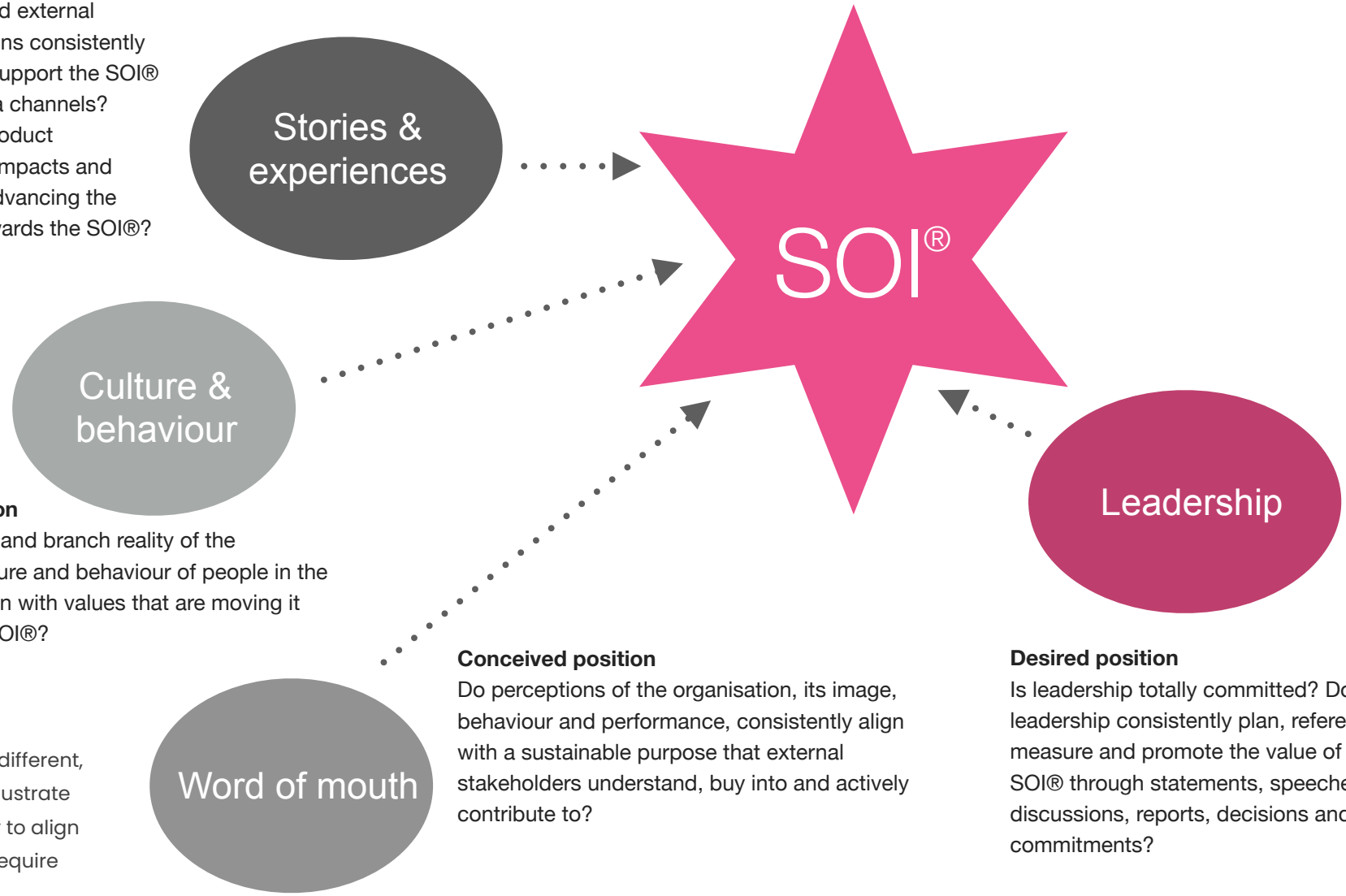
For this reason, SOI® implementation should be viewed as a process of evolution rather than revolution. The objective is not to impose change for its own sake, but to create steady, meaningful progress towards a more coherent, purpose-driven organisation.

The role of leadership is critical. Leaders must consistently reinforce the Strategic Framework through decisions, priorities, communications, governance and resource allocation. Employees pay far more attention to what leaders do than what they say. Alignment therefore begins at the top.

The objective of Total Alignment is straightforward: to ensure that every part of the organisation is moving towards the same destination. The sections that follow provide a practical framework for achieving that outcome by focusing on the key organisational domains that shape performance, culture and impact.

When these domains begin working together in support of a common purpose, organisations become more focused, more resilient and more capable of creating long-term commercial and societal value. They become truly purpose driven.

Communicated position
Do internal and external communications consistently express and support the SOI® through media channels? Are service/product experiences, impacts and innovations advancing the enterprise towards the SOI®?



Actual position
Does the root and branch reality of the structure, culture and behaviour of people in the enterprise align with values that are moving it towards the SOI®?

Conceived position
Do perceptions of the organisation, its image, behaviour and performance, consistently align with a sustainable purpose that external stakeholders understand, buy into and actively contribute to?

Desired position
Is leadership totally committed? Does leadership consistently plan, reference, measure and promote the value of the SOI® through statements, speeches, discussions, reports, decisions and commitments?

Every organisation is different, but the dotted lines illustrate which areas are likely to align first and which may require more time and effort.

Inspired by Professor John Balmer's ACCID test

4.2 BUSINESS FUNCTIONS

Every organisation is different.
Some have traditional functional structures. Others operate through business units, projects, networks, regions or specialist teams. The purpose of this section is therefore not to prescribe a particular organisational design, but to provide a practical framework for alignment.

The six business functions described in the following pages represent common organisational domains that influence performance, culture and impact. While the names and structures may vary from one organisation to another, the underlying principles remain the same.

The objective is to ensure that the Positioning Statement, Core Values and Single Organizing Idea® are translated into practical action across the organisation. This process rarely begins with wholesale restructuring. Most organisations already have strategies, planning processes, performance measures, governance mechanisms and management systems in place. The role of the Associate is not to replace these automatically, but to determine whether they support the SOI® and, where necessary, help realign them.

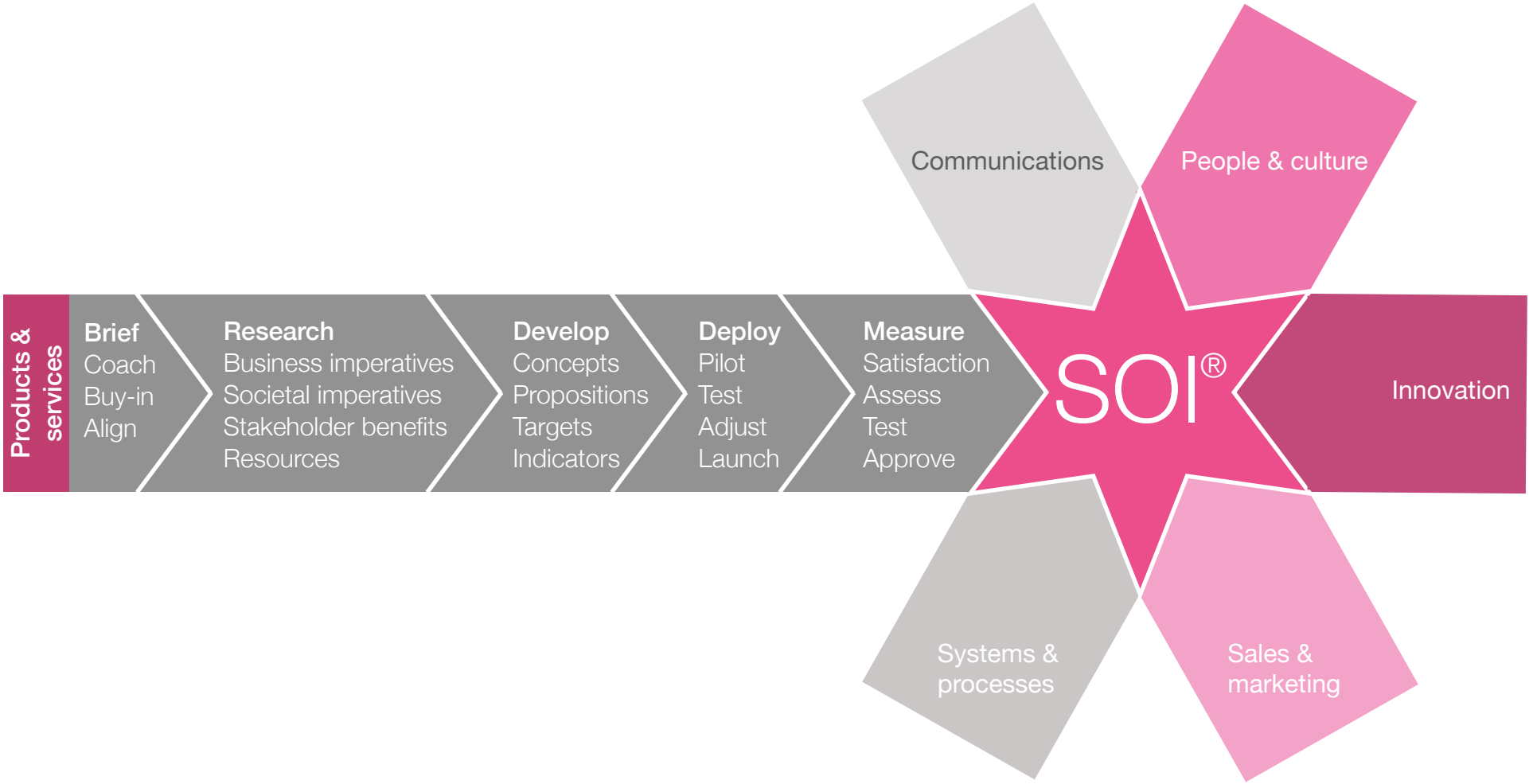
A useful starting point is to work with leadership teams to develop a small number of ambition statements aligned with the SOI®. These ambitions describe what success would look like if the organisation were fully aligned with its purpose. Strategic goals, priorities and performance measures can then be developed beneath them.

This creates a clear line of sight between the SOI®, the organisation's ambitions, its strategic objectives and the activities carried out every day.

The six business functions that follow provide a practical way of identifying opportunities, gaps, barriers and priorities for alignment. Some areas will require significant change, while others may already be strongly aligned. The task is to understand the difference and determine where effort should be focused first.

Alignment is not a one-off exercise. It is an ongoing process of improvement that gradually brings every part of the organisation into closer alignment with its purpose.

When this happens, purpose moves beyond strategy and becomes embedded in the way the organisation operates, creates value and measures success.


Products & services
Brief
Coach
Buy-in
Align
Research
Business imperatives
Societal imperatives
Stakeholder benefits
Resources
Develop
Concepts
Propositions
Targets
Indicators
Deploy
Pilot
Test
Adjust
Launch
Measure
Satisfaction
Assess
Test
Approve
SOI®
Innovation
Communications
People & culture
Systems & processes
Sales & marketing

4.2/1 PEOPLE & CULTURE

People and culture are often the first areas in which alignment with an SOI® becomes visible.

Strategies, systems and structures all matter, but it is people who ultimately bring purpose to life through their decisions, behaviours and actions. If people do not understand the SOI®, believe in it or see its relevance to their role, alignment will remain limited regardless of how well the strategy has been defined.

For this reason, leadership attention should focus first on building understanding and commitment.

The objective is not simply to communicate the SOI®, but to help people understand what it means, why it matters and how they can contribute to its success.

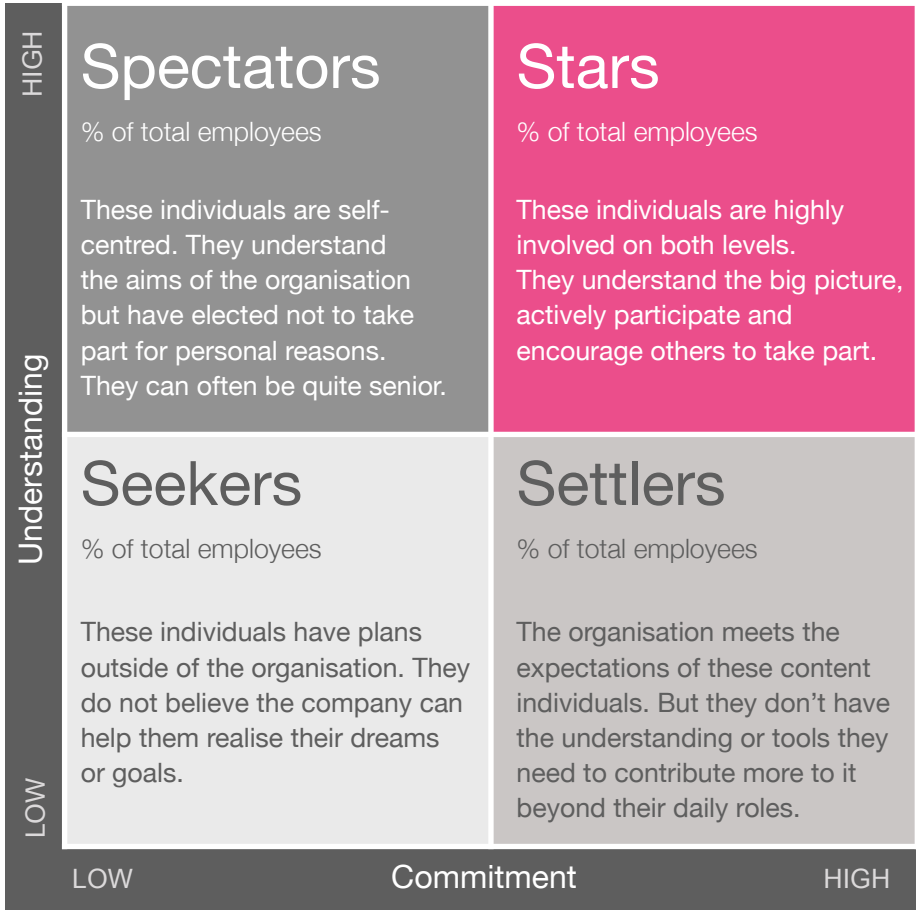
The Core Values play a critical role in this process. They provide practical guidance on the actions, behaviours and attitudes required to deliver the SOI® and should be reflected in recruitment, induction, development, recognition, promotion and performance management processes.

A useful exercise is to assess employees against two dimensions: their understanding of the SOI® and their commitment to it. This helps identify where additional communication, support, development or leadership intervention may be required.

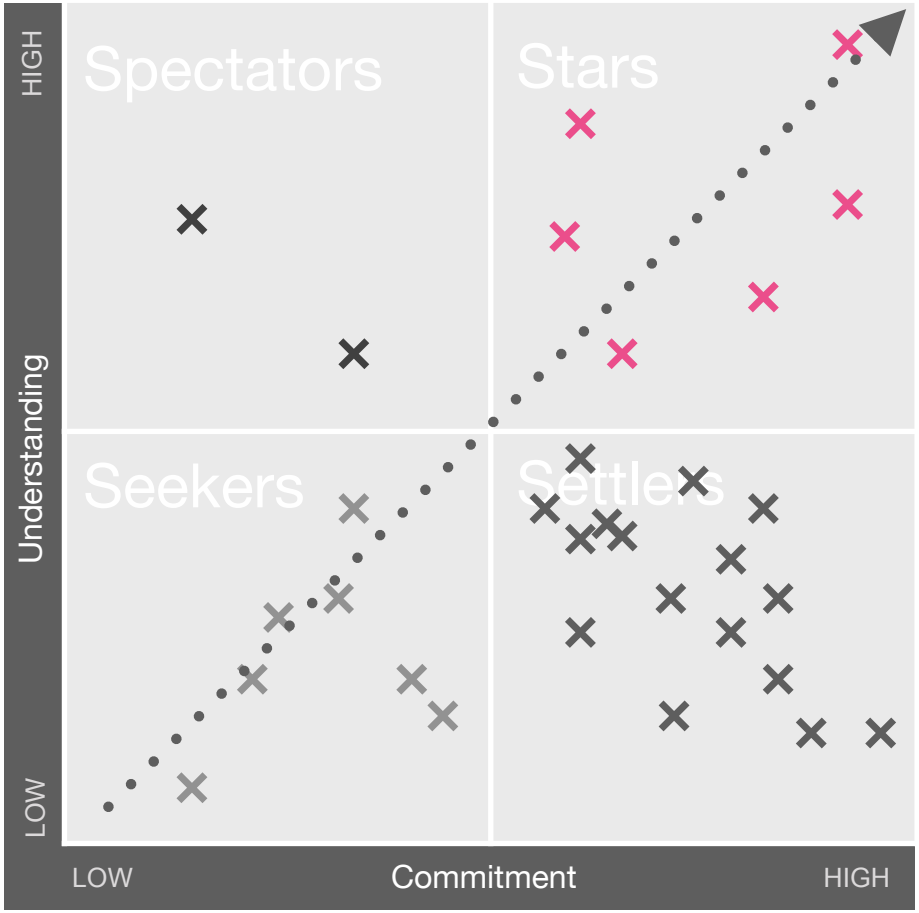
Associates should also recognise that cultural change takes time. Existing beliefs, habits and ways of working will not change overnight. Progress is usually achieved through a combination of leadership example, clear expectations, reinforcement and visible successes.

When people understand the destination, believe in the journey and feel empowered to contribute, purpose begins to move from strategy into everyday practice.

Culture is not something that sits alongside the SOI®. It is one of the primary mechanisms through which the SOI® is delivered.



Alignment with an SOI® gives people a shared objective they care about. The result is greater engagement, stronger performance, improved retention and better stakeholder experiences.



Assessing alignment with the SOI® goes beyond traditional HR measures. The objective is to understand how each role contributes to delivering outcomes that support the SOI®.

4.2/1 PEOPLE & CULTURE (cont.)

Understanding the Value of Values
The actions, behaviours and attitudes of people are the single biggest factor influencing successful alignment.
If people do not understand the organisation's Core Values and their role in delivering the SOI®, alignment will remain limited regardless of how strong the strategy is. The purpose of this short workshop is to help participants understand how values influence decisions and behaviour, both personally and professionally.

Step 1 – Working in Pairs
Participants ask each other:
"What are the most important values in your life?"
Each value and its meaning is recorded using the participant's own words. Once completed, roles are reversed.

Step 2 – Prioritising Values
Participants review their lists and identify:

- Which values are always important?
- Which values are sometimes important?

Similar values should be combined until a shortlist of no more than five remains.

Step 3 – Group Discussion
The group comes together to discuss how personal values can help reinforce the organisation's Core Values and support the delivery of the SOI®.

A version of this exercise can also be incorporated into recruitment and onboarding processes to help attract and develop people who align with the organisation's purpose and values.

Living and Breathing It
Core Values are not decorative statements. They provide practical guidance for decision-making, performance and behaviour.

Recruitment, development, recognition, promotion and performance management processes should all reflect the Core Values. Consistently reinforced through leadership actions and everyday decisions, they help create a shared culture, clear expectations and a sense of collective purpose.

Standing Together
Leadership is an action, not a position. Everyone has a role to play in delivering the SOI®, although their opportunities to influence progress will differ.

As a general guide:

Leaders should be recognised for:

- Building confidence in the SOI® among stakeholders.
- Driving and supporting transformation.
- Demonstrating the Core Values through their actions.

Managers should be recognised for:

- Coordinating alignment activities.
- Encouraging collaboration.
- Building a culture of shared success.

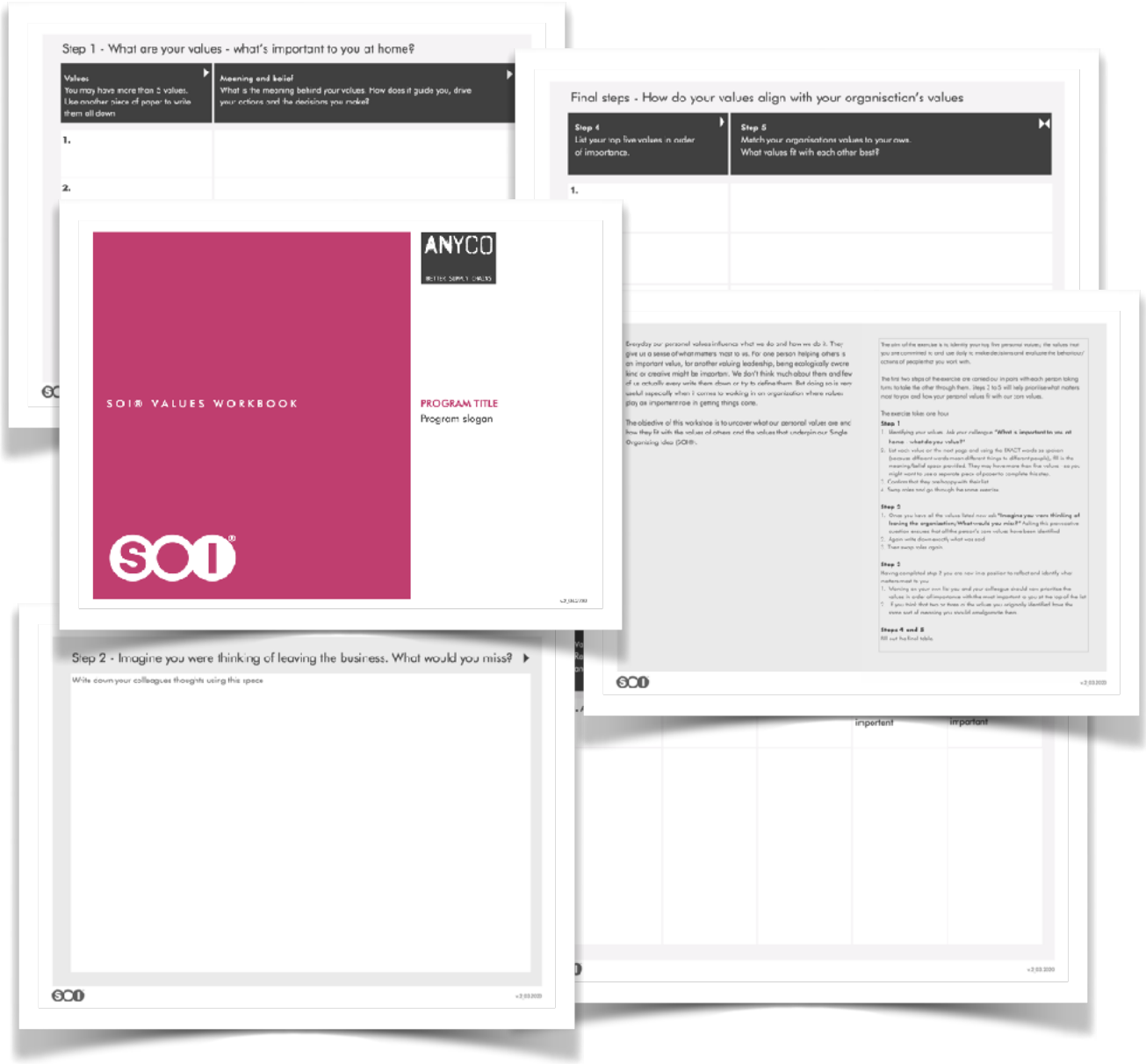
Employees should be recognised for:

- Participating in alignment efforts.
- Providing feedback and ideas.
- Demonstrating the Core Values in practice.

Celebration

Doing the right thing does not always require reward, but it should always be recognised.

Celebrating progress, milestones and successes helps reinforce commitment to the SOI®, build pride and strengthen the sense of shared achievement that sits at the heart of a purpose-driven organisation.



4.2/2 INNOVATION

Many organisations invest in research and development, but relatively few create mechanisms that enable employees and stakeholders to contribute ideas that improve the organisation, its value chain and the wider ecosystem.

Once the SOI® has been defined and validated, it can provide a powerful focus for innovation. Employees and stakeholders can be challenged to identify opportunities that support the SOI®, improve performance, create societal value or solve real-world problems.

This creates an opportunity to build on the momentum generated during the Identify and Define phases by encouraging people to start new initiatives, improve existing activities and eliminate practices that no longer support the organisation's purpose.

The innovation framework illustrated opposite can be adapted to suit the needs of the client organisation. Some organisations may choose to create a dedicated innovation programme linked directly to their SOI®, while others may embed innovation within existing planning and improvement processes.

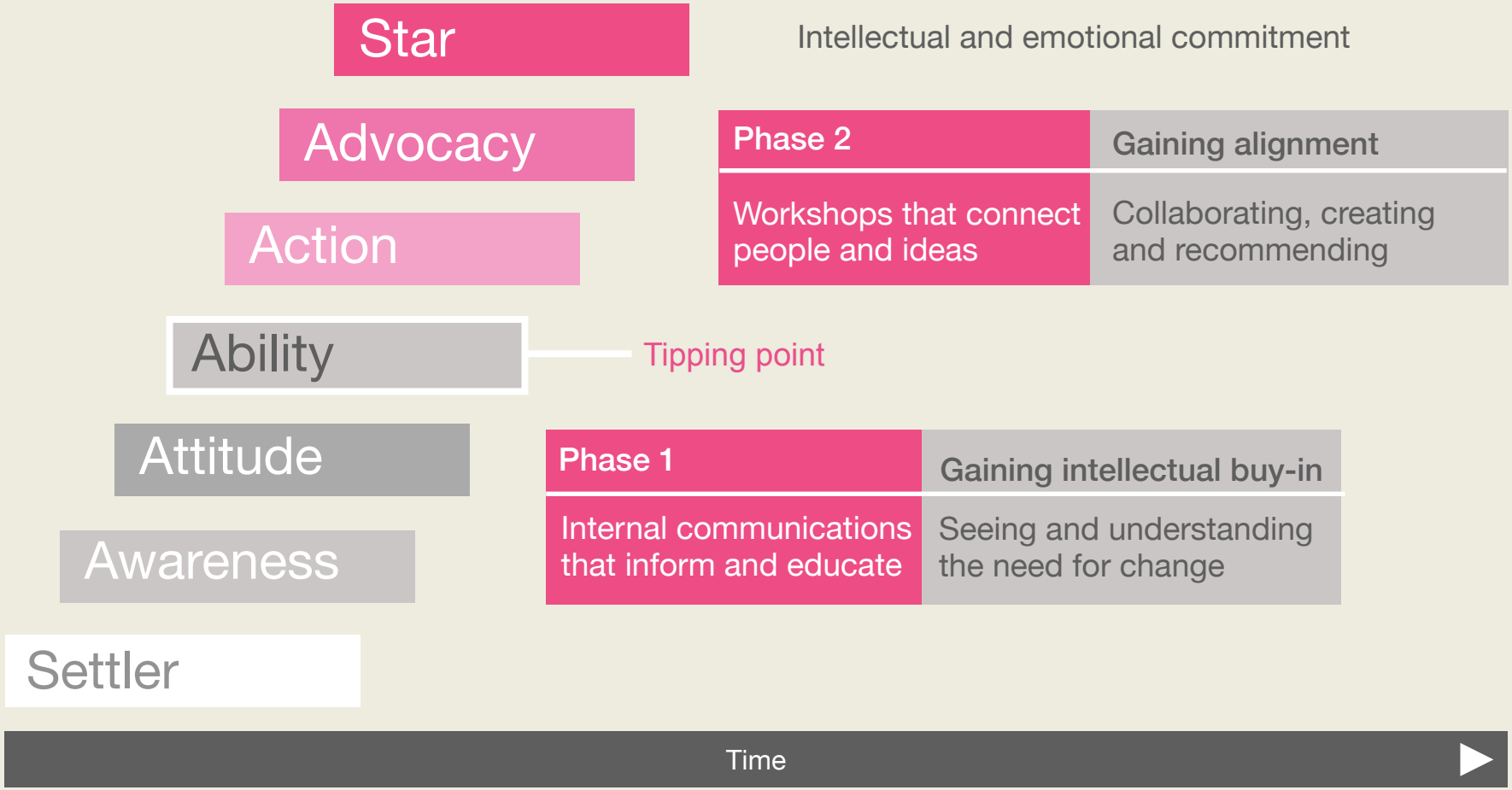
The objective is the same: to create a practical mechanism for generating, evaluating and implementing ideas that support the SOI®.

Well-designed innovation programmes encourage collaboration, strengthen stakeholder engagement and create a continuous flow of improvement opportunities. They also generate valuable stories and evidence that demonstrate the organisation's commitment to delivering its purpose in practice.

Examples such as Toyota's continuous improvement culture and Google's encouragement of employee-led innovation show the value of creating environments in which ideas can emerge from anywhere within the organisation.

Today, digital collaboration tools and AI can also help generate ideas, identify patterns, evaluate opportunities and accelerate learning. However, innovation remains fundamentally a human activity. The role of technology is to support creativity and judgement, not replace them.

Organisations that make innovation part of everyday life are often better equipped to adapt, improve and create long-term value for both their stakeholders and society.



An SOI® fosters collaboration and innovation, creating value for all stakeholders. Achieving the high-performance culture this enables requires leadership, commitment and time.

4.2/2 INNOVATION (cont.)

The objective of the innovation programme is to generate practical ideas that improve the organisation, strengthen alignment with the SOI® and create value for stakeholders.

Participation should be encouraged across the organisation. Involving people from all parts of the organisation in identifying opportunities for improvement not only generates ideas, but also builds understanding, ownership and commitment to the SOI®.

Implementing ideas is critical. Nothing demonstrates commitment to the SOI® more clearly than turning stakeholder suggestions into visible action. Successful innovations improve performance, strengthen reputation and provide tangible evidence that the organisation is serious about continuous improvement.

The programme is divided into three phases:

Phase 1 – Idea Generation
Workshops are facilitated by designated champions who guide participants through three exercises:

Exercise 1: Story Harvest
Participants share examples of the SOI® and Core Values already being demonstrated within the organisation. These stories can be captured, curated and shared as examples of purpose in action.

Exercise 2: Touch-Points
Participants identify the key touch-points within their area of responsibility and prioritise those where improvement would have the greatest impact.

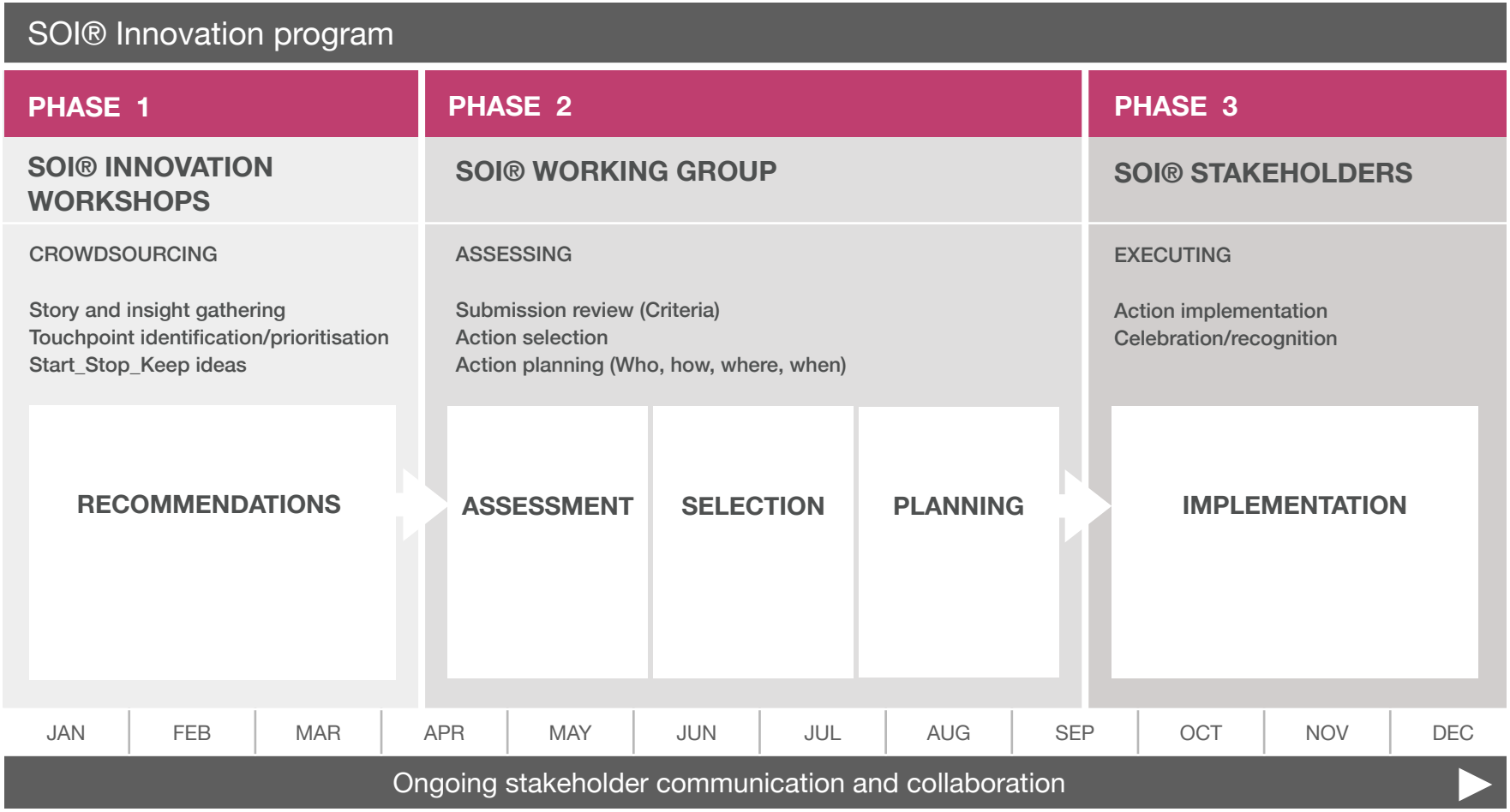
Exercise 3: Start–Stop–Keep
For each priority touch-point, participants identify:

- What should be started.
- What should be stopped.
- What should be continued because it already supports the SOI®.

Phase 2 – Evaluation and Planning
Ideas are reviewed and prioritised. Actions, responsibilities, resources and timeframes are then agreed and incorporated into the organisation's implementation plans.

Phase 3 – Implementation and Recognition
Progress and outcomes are communicated throughout the organisation. Contributions should be recognised and successful innovations celebrated, reinforcing the role that employees and stakeholders play in delivering the SOI®.

Over time, the innovation programme becomes a practical mechanism for continuous improvement, helping ensure that the SOI® remains relevant, visible and embedded in everyday organisational life.



New ideas create momentum, encourage participation and drive improvement. The innovation programme provides a practical framework that can be adapted to suit the organisation's needs and resources.

4.2/3 PRODUCTS & SERVICES

Ultimately, the success of any organisation depends on the value that stakeholders derive from its products and services.

Alignment with an SOI® requires organisations to review their products and services through the lens of purpose. Some offerings may already support the SOI® strongly. Others may require improvement, repositioning or, in some cases, retirement.

This is often where purpose becomes tangible. Decisions about what an organisation creates, delivers and invests in send powerful signals to employees, customers, investors and wider stakeholders about what it truly stands for.

For many organisations, this can be one of the most challenging aspects of alignment. Existing products and services may generate significant revenue, yet contribute little towards the long-term ambition expressed by the SOI®. Equally, emerging opportunities that align strongly with the SOI® may require investment, patience and a willingness to embrace change.

The role of the Associate is not to make these decisions for the client organisation, but to help leadership teams evaluate their product and service portfolio through a broader lens that considers commercial performance, stakeholder value, societal impact and long-term sustainability.

Better by Design
Good design is not simply about aesthetics. It is about creating products and services that are useful, understandable, sustainable and aligned with stakeholder needs.

The celebrated designer Dieter Rams argued that good design should be innovative, useful, honest, long-lasting, environmentally responsible and as simple as possible. Those principles remain highly relevant today.

The most successful products and services are often those that solve genuine problems in simple, effective and meaningful ways. They create value for customers while reinforcing the organisation's purpose and reputation.

Guided by the SOI®, recognised standards and stakeholder expectations, organisations can use these principles to develop products and services that create value while contributing positively to society and the environment.

Alignment in Action
The following five-stage process provides a practical framework for aligning products and services with the SOI®.

Phase 1 – Introduce
Ensure that everyone involved in product and service development understands the

SOI® Strategic Framework and its role in guiding decision-making.

Phase 2 – Research
Assess stakeholder needs, market opportunities, emerging trends and relevant standards. Define requirements, resources and objectives.

Phase 3 – Develop
Develop and test concepts, prototypes or pilot services. Evaluate commercial, social and environmental considerations and ensure alignment with the SOI®.

Phase 4 – Deploy
Launch the product or service following appropriate testing and quality assurance processes.

Phase 5 – Measure
Monitor performance, gather feedback and identify opportunities for improvement. Use the insights gained to refine existing offers and inform future development.

AI can support research, concept development, customer insight analysis and rapid prototyping throughout this process. However, decisions about what should be created and why should remain grounded in human judgement, stakeholder needs and the organisation's purpose.

Products and services aligned with a clear SOI® are more likely to remain relevant, create stakeholder value and contribute to long-term organisational success. They also provide some of the strongest evidence that purpose is not merely being discussed, but actively delivered.

Alignment is not simply about creating new products and services. It is equally about evaluating existing ones. Associates should encourage leadership teams to consider whether current offerings genuinely support the organisation's SOI®, values and long-term ambitions. Some products and services may require enhancement, others may need repositioning, and a small number may no longer fit the direction of travel. These decisions are rarely straightforward, but they provide valuable opportunities to strengthen focus, improve resource allocation and ensure that investment is directed towards areas that create the greatest long-term value.

Purpose-driven organisations are often distinguished not only by what they choose to do, but also by what they choose not to do. Clarity about priorities helps prevent resources being spread too thinly and enables innovation efforts to be focused on opportunities that reinforce the organisation's strategic intent.

4.2/4 COMMUNICATION

It is important that stakeholders, and employees in particular, understand why the SOI® matters and how it will influence the future direction of the organisation.

Communication plays a critical role in building understanding, engagement and trust. However, purpose-led communications require care. Messages must be credible, transparent and supported by evidence. Overstating progress or making claims that are not reflected in reality can quickly undermine confidence and damage reputation.

A useful principle is to recognise the gap between aspiration and reality.

Organisations are rarely fully aligned with their SOI® from day one. Alignment is a journey that takes time, commitment and sustained effort. Communications should therefore focus on progress rather than perfection and invite stakeholders to participate in that journey.

The experience of BP's well-known "Beyond Petroleum" campaign illustrates the importance of managing expectations.

The ambition was compelling, but many stakeholders felt that the organisation's actions did not yet match its communications. The lesson is clear: purpose-led communications must be grounded in evidence and accompanied by visible action.

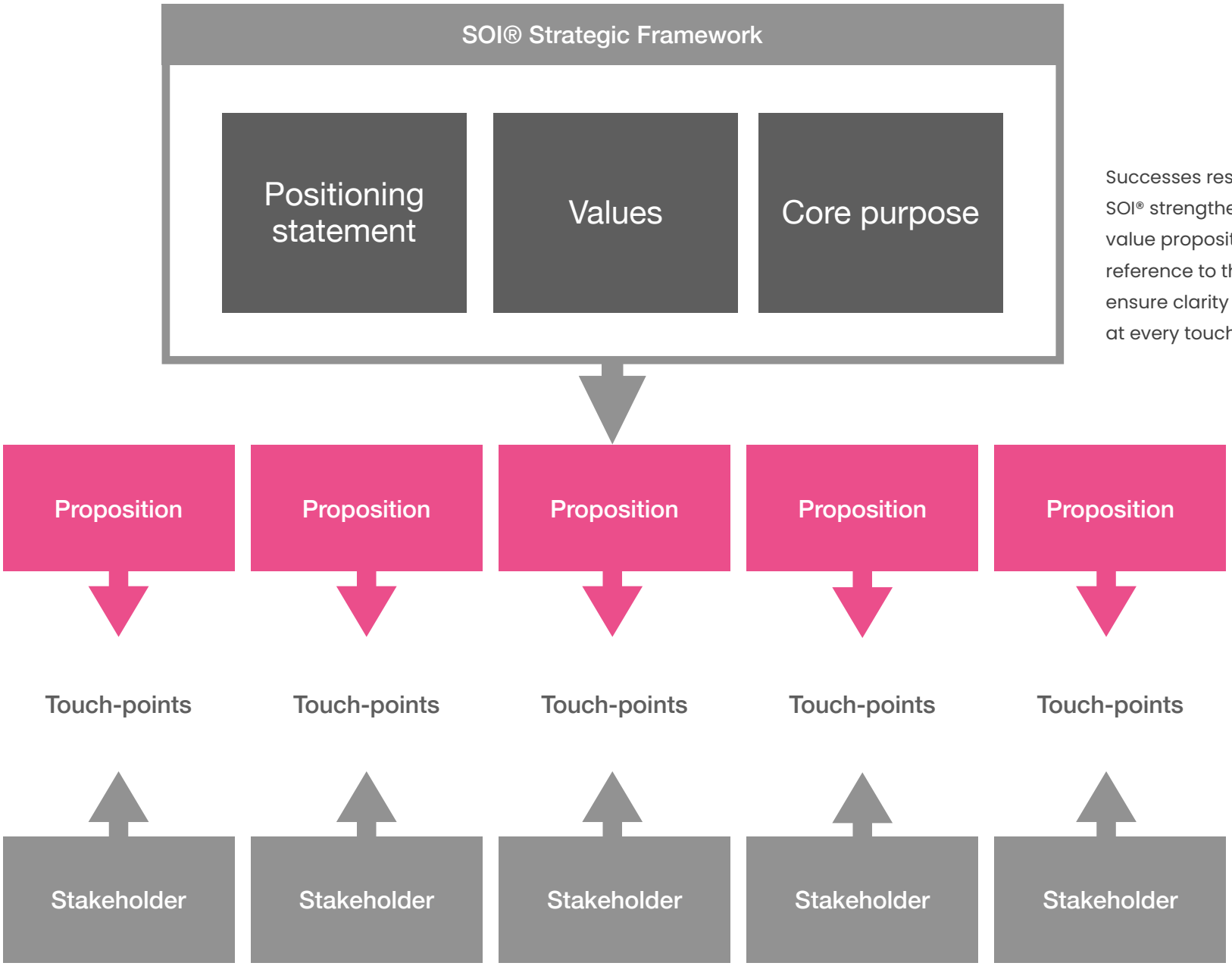
For Associates, this means helping client organisations communicate honestly about where they are today, where they are trying to get to and how they intend to measure progress. Credibility is built when actions and communications reinforce one another.

Goals, milestones and performance measures provide a useful framework for ongoing communication. Regular updates on achievements, challenges and lessons learned help create a sense of shared progress while strengthening accountability and trust.

Communication should also be viewed as a two-way process. Listening to stakeholders can provide valuable insight into changing expectations, emerging risks and new opportunities for improvement.

Websites, reports, events, social media channels, product information and internal communications all provide opportunities to share progress and demonstrate the practical impact of the SOI®.

When communication is aligned with action, it becomes one of the most powerful tools available for building trust, strengthening reputation and sustaining momentum.



Successes resulting from the SOI® strengthen stakeholder value propositions. Consistent reference to the SOI® helps ensure clarity and coherence at every touch-point.

4.2/5 SALES & MARKETING

Sales and marketing play a critical role in communicating the value of an organisation's products and services. Within an SOI®-aligned organisation, however, they should be guided by strategy rather than drive it.

Many organisations find themselves continually reacting to changing market conditions, competitor activity and shifting customer preferences. The result can be fragmented messaging, short-term initiatives and product or service developments that lack strategic coherence.

The SOI® provides a more stable reference point.

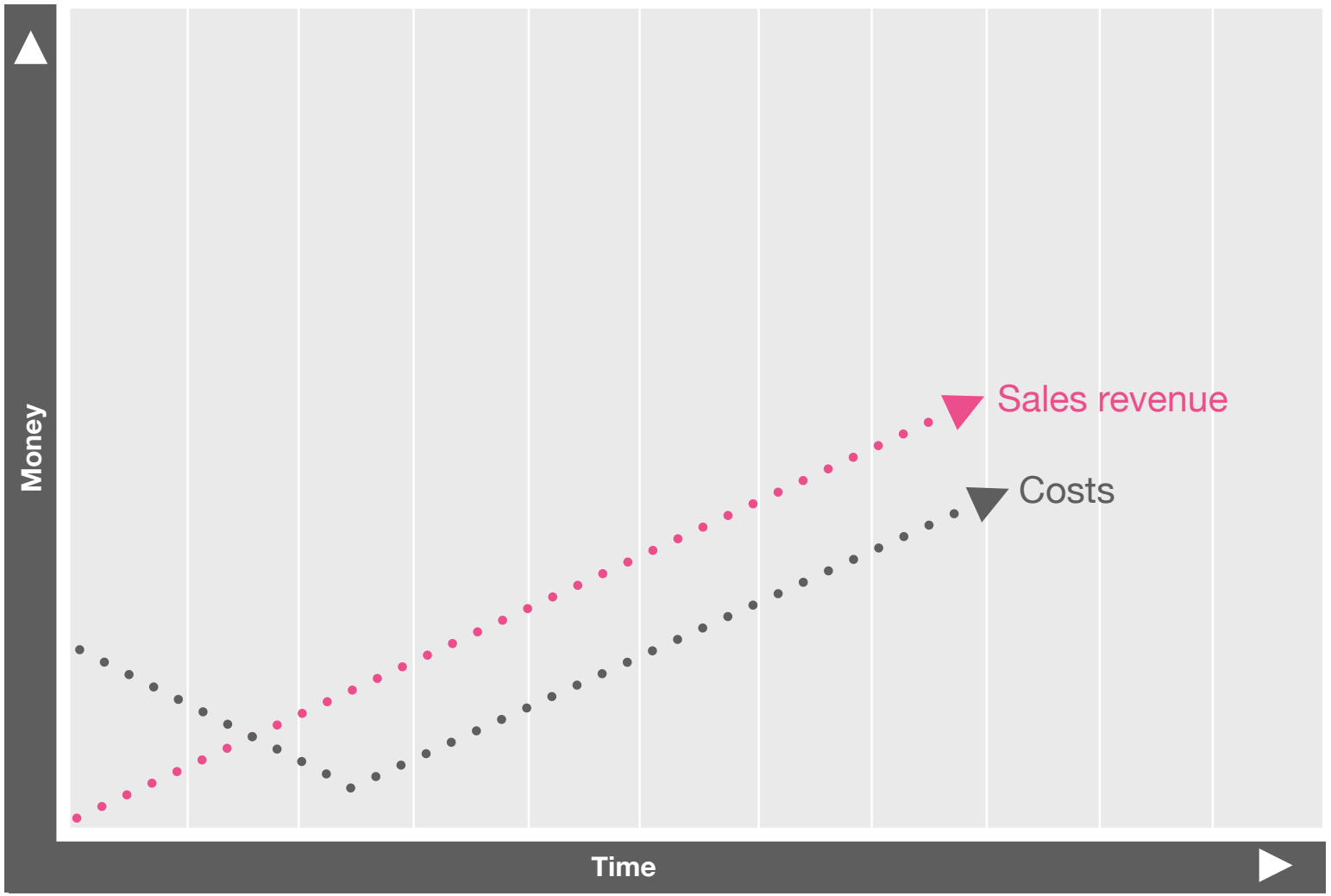
Designed to remain relevant regardless of changes in technology, management trends or market conditions, the SOI® enables organisations to take a longer-term view of value creation. Rather than chasing every opportunity, decisions can be evaluated against a clear understanding of purpose, positioning and stakeholder needs.

The role of sales and marketing is to communicate the organisation's value proposition in a way that is authentic, relevant and aligned with the SOI®.

Messages, campaigns, channels and customer experiences should reinforce the same underlying purpose and positioning. This alignment is important because every interaction with a customer is a moment of truth. Marketing promises must be supported by products, services and behaviours that consistently deliver on those promises.

AI and digital tools can help organisations better understand customer needs, personalise communications and improve engagement. However, these technologies are most effective when guided by a clear strategic direction and genuine stakeholder insight.

Regular feedback, customer surveys and performance reviews should be used to monitor progress and identify opportunities for improvement.
When sales and marketing are aligned with the SOI®, they become a powerful force for building trust, strengthening relationships and supporting long-term success.



Profit is not an end in itself. It is the fuel that enables an organisation to thrive and create long-term value for stakeholders.The objective is sustainable success: delivering both financial performance and the ambitions embodied in the SOI®.

4.2/6 PROCESSES & SYSTEMS

Processes and systems influence every aspect of organisational performance, from productivity and innovation to customer experience, people management and financial results.

Once the SOI® Strategic Framework has been defined, it must be translated into practical action. This is achieved by establishing a clear line of sight between the SOI®, the organisation's ambitions, its strategic goals and the systems used to deliver them.

A useful approach is to begin by defining a small number of ambition statements aligned with the SOI®. These describe what success would look like if the organisation were fully aligned with its purpose.

Strategic goals, priorities and performance measures can then be developed beneath them.

This process helps convert purpose from an idea into a practical framework for action.

Without clear goals and measures, the SOI® risks becoming little more than an interesting concept. With them, it becomes a mechanism for directing resources, guiding decision-making and driving continuous improvement. Associates should work with client organisations to review existing processes, systems, policies and standards to determine whether they support the SOI®.

In many cases, the required changes will be evolutionary rather than revolutionary. Existing systems often provide a strong foundation and simply need refining, connecting or realigning.

Goals and objectives should be clear, understandable and capable of being measured. They should motivate action, establish accountability and provide a basis for tracking progress over time. While an organisation has only one SOI®, it will typically have multiple goals and measures across different functions and teams. Together, these create the structure through which alignment is achieved and sustained.

The more effectively processes and systems support the SOI®, the more consistently the organisation will deliver on its promises. This is where purpose moves beyond aspiration and becomes embedded in the day-to-day operation of the organisation.

SOI® Reward and recognition scheme		
Innovation awards	**Culture awards**	**Community awards**
Staff teams recognised and rewarded for **start-stop-keep** ideas that support your SOI®	Individuals recognised and rewarded for actions/ behaviours aligned with the **values** that support your SOI®	External ecosystem **partners/ partnerships** recognised and rewarded for start-stop-keep ideas that align with your SOI®
Awarded annually Judgement by leadership Managed by peer elected team	**Awarded annually/monthly** Judgement by peers and leadership Managed by elected working group	**Awarded annually** Judgement by leadership Managed by elected working group
Reward value/type Rankings/categories	**Reward value/type** Rankings/categories	**Reward value/type** Rankings/categories
Assessment criteria Alignment with SOI® Potential impact Return on investment (ROI) Implementation speed	**Assessment criteria** Alignment with values Impact of actions/behaviour	**Assessment criteria** Alignment with SOI® Potential impact
Communications Pre-award campaign Award publicity Post-award publicity	**Communications** Pre-award campaign Award publicity Post-award publicity	**Communications** Pre-award campaign Award publicity Post-award publicity
Event(s) responsibility, planning, management and costing		

When linked to an SOI®, recognition celebrates the actions, behaviours and achievements that advance purpose and create value for stakeholders and society.

4.3 SOI® ALIGNMENT CANVAS

The SOI® Alignment Canvas is a practical planning tool that helps translate the SOI® Strategic Framework into actions, responsibilities and measurable outcomes.

If the SOI® Strategic Framework defines the destination, the Alignment Canvas helps map the route. It provides a visual overview of how the organisation intends to move from aspiration to implementation.

Used as a working document, the canvas helps leadership teams prioritise activities, allocate resources and monitor progress. It should be reviewed and updated regularly as circumstances and priorities evolve.

The Alignment Canvas is not the only way to manage implementation. Many organisations already use tools such as Strategy on a Page, Balanced Scorecards, OKRs, annual business plans or strategic roadmaps. The important point is not the tool itself, but whether it creates a clear line of sight between the SOI®, organisational ambitions, strategic goals, actions and measures.

The Alignment Canvas contains three sections:

1. SOI® Strategic Framework

This section contains the three elements that guide decision-making:

- Single Organizing Idea®
- Core Values
- Positioning Statement

These remain constant and provide the reference point for all alignment activity.

2. Alignment Commitments

This section captures the commitments required to align the organisation with its SOI®.

These commitments answer a simple question:

"What should we start, stop or keep doing to better align with our SOI®?"

Ideas are reviewed, prioritised and organised into short-, medium- and long-term commitments.

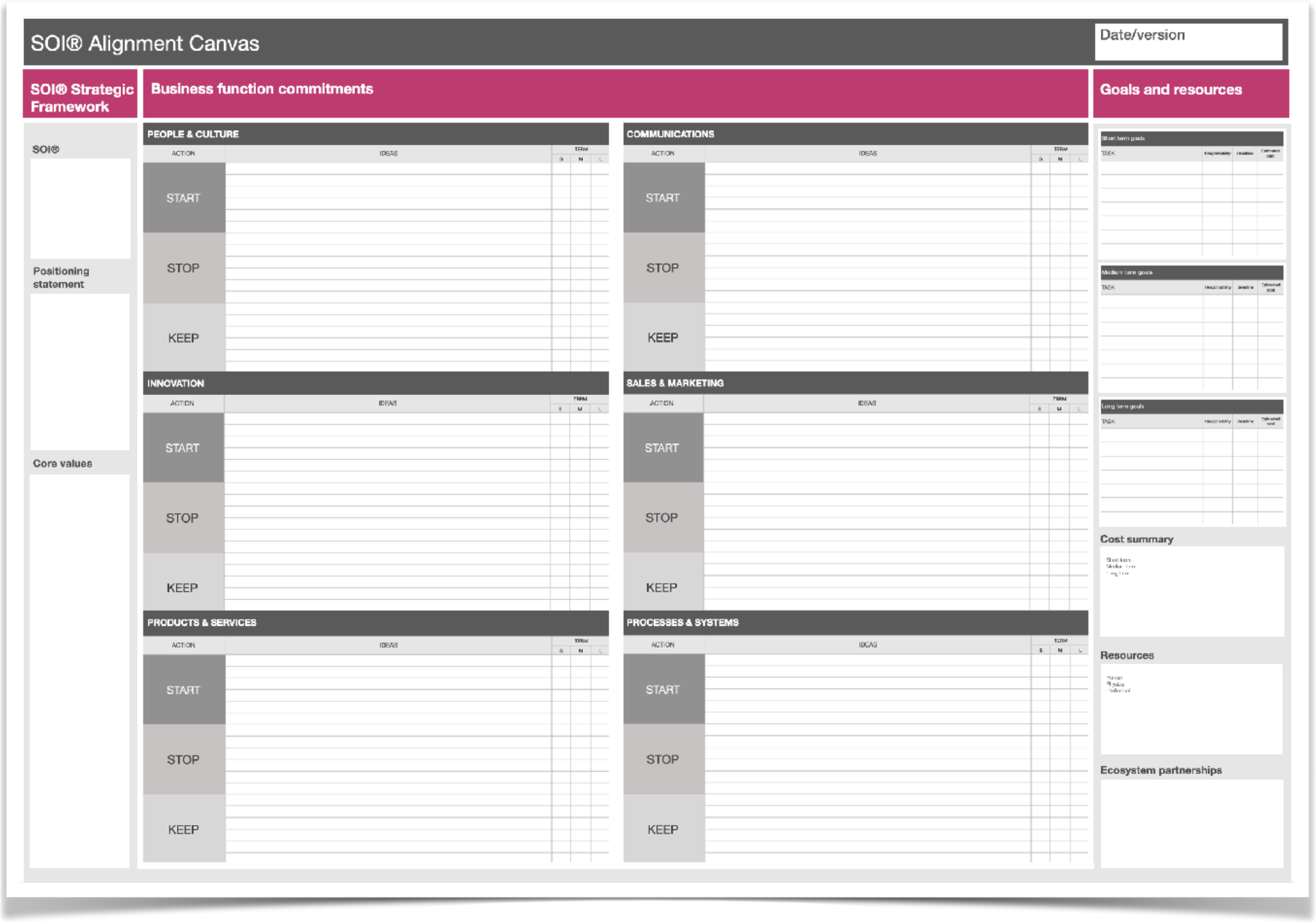
3. Goals and Resources

The final section translates commitments into action.

It records strategic goals, responsibilities, timescales, resource requirements and performance measures, together with key partnerships and capabilities needed to support delivery.

The Alignment Canvas provides a high-level view of the alignment journey, while supporting plans capture the implementation detail.

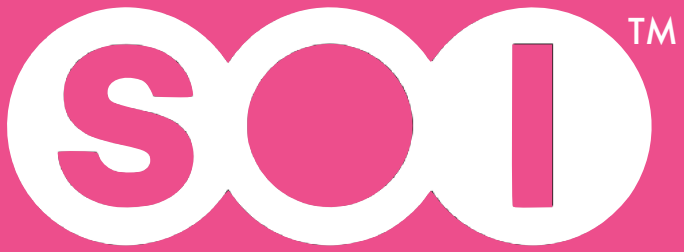
Like all the tools in this Playbook, it should be adapted to suit the needs of the client organisation.


SOI® Alignment Canvas
Date/version
SOI® Strategic Framework
Business function commitments
Goals and resources
SOI®
Positioning statement
Core values
PEOPLE & CULTURE
COMMUNICATIONS
INNOVATION
SALES & MARKETING
PRODUCTS & SERVICES
PROCESSES & SYSTEMS
ACTION
IDEAS
TERM
START
STOP
KEEP
Cost summary
Resources
Ecosystem partnerships

KEY POINTS

- Alignment is the process of translating the SOI® Strategic Framework into actions, behaviours, systems and measures that guide everyday decision-making.
- Every organisation is different. The objective is not to replace existing structures and processes, but to ensure they support the SOI® and long-term organisational ambitions.
- Ambition statements, strategic goals and performance measures create a clear line of sight between purpose and practical action.
- Successful alignment requires leadership commitment, stakeholder engagement and continuous improvement across all organisational domains.
- • Purpose becomes real when it is reflected consistently in products and services, people and culture, communications, sales and marketing, innovation, and the processes and systems used to deliver value.

YOUR NOTES



SINGLE

ORGANIZING

IDEA

5.0

85-100

MEASURE

How to measure performance, understand impact and drive continuous learning.

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5.2 INTERNAL PERFORMANCE METRICS 91

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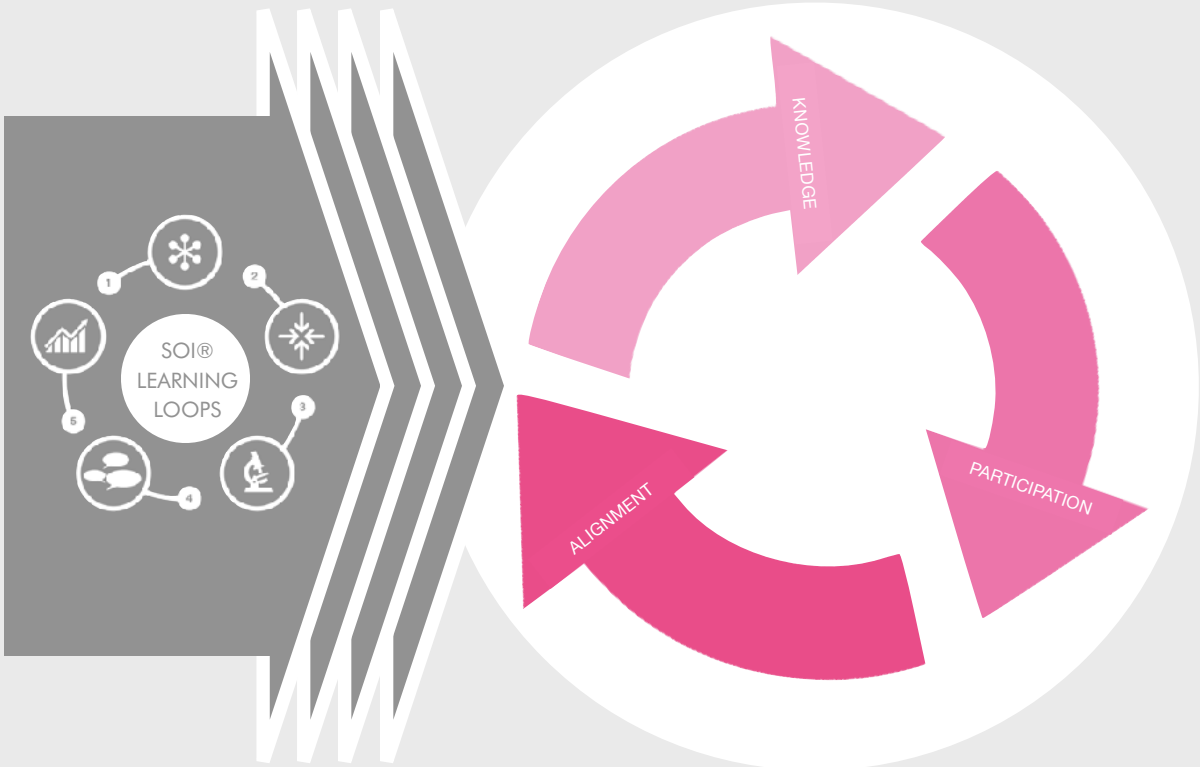
5.5 LEARNING TO THRIVE 97

5.1 LEARNING LOOPS

Measurement is essential to organisational success. Without it, leaders are left to rely on assumptions, anecdotes and intuition when making decisions. While purpose provides direction and alignment turns intent into action, measurement helps determine whether those actions are producing the outcomes the organisation intended. Simply put, organisations improve what they understand.

For purpose-driven organisations, measurement serves a second and equally important role. It provides evidence of progress, builds accountability and creates opportunities for learning. The most effective organisations do not measure simply to report performance; they measure to understand what is working, what is not and what needs to change.

This is where Learning Loops become invaluable.



Learning Loops help organisations understand what is working, what is not and what needs to change. By combining measurement, feedback and action, they turn data into learning and learning into improvement.

How do you know whether the SOI® is delivering the outcomes it was designed to achieve? How do you know whether alignment efforts are working? Most importantly, how do you know what needs to improve?

The answer lies in creating effective Learning Loops.

Learning Loops provide a structured way of gathering feedback, measuring progress and identifying opportunities for improvement. They help organisations understand whether their actions are creating the intended results and ensure that learning becomes a continuous part of organisational life.

Measurement is not an end in itself. The purpose of measurement is to generate insight that supports better decisions, stronger alignment and improved outcomes.

Many organisations collect large amounts of data but fail to convert it into meaningful action. Others rely on annual surveys and reporting processes that provide only an occasional snapshot of performance. Learning Loops are designed to create a regular rhythm of listening, learning and improving that helps organisations remain relevant, responsive and aligned with their purpose.

By engaging stakeholders in the process, Learning Loops create a continuous flow of information that helps organisations understand both performance and impact. They also strengthen trust by demonstrating that stakeholder views are being listened to and acted upon.

In the early stages of implementation, Learning Loops can play an important role in building awareness and momentum around the SOI®. As stakeholders begin to see their feedback influencing decisions and improvements, participation and engagement often increase. Over time, this creates a virtuous cycle in which learning drives action, action drives improvement and improvement generates greater confidence in the organisation's purpose and direction.

Learning Loops focus on two areas:

- **Performance** – whether the SOI®, Core Values and strategic goals are being lived in practice.
- **Impact** – whether stakeholders believe the organisation is creating meaningful value for them and for society.

Step 1: Design

Decide what you want to learn and which stakeholder groups should be involved. Develop a small number of questions that focus on performance, impact and opportunities for improvement. Questions should be relevant to the stakeholder group being engaged and linked, wherever possible, to the ambitions,

5.1 LEARNING LOOPS (cont.)

goals and measures established during the Align phase.

Step 2: Collect
Gather feedback at key touch-points throughout the stakeholder experience. Short pulse surveys, conversations, workshops and digital feedback tools are often more effective than large, infrequent surveys. The objective is to create a regular flow of useful information rather than large volumes of data.
Stakeholders are increasingly overwhelmed by requests for feedback. Participation rates improve when organisations explain why they are asking questions, how the information will be used and what actions may result.
AI tools can help gather, organise and analyse feedback at scale, but the focus should remain on understanding people rather than simply collecting information.

Step 3: Analyse
Review the data to identify patterns, themes, opportunities and concerns. Keep the analysis simple and practical. Focus on the issues that are most relevant to each stakeholder group and most important to the organisation's ambitions and goals.

Comparing responses across stakeholder groups can be particularly revealing. Differences in perception often highlight opportunities for improvement that may otherwise remain hidden.

Step 4: Discuss
Share the findings with stakeholders and involve them in interpreting the results and identifying possible improvements. This is often the most important stage of the process. Learning Loops work best when stakeholders can see that their views are being heard and considered. The objective is not simply to report findings but to create meaningful dialogue that helps generate better solutions and stronger alignment.

Step 5: Improve
Agree actions, implement changes and communicate progress.

The final step is to measure again. By monitoring the effect of improvement actions over time, organisations create a continuous cycle of learning, adaptation and progress.

Learning Loops help organisations remain aligned with their purpose while responding to changing stakeholder expectations and operating environments.

They provide a practical mechanism for turning measurement into learning and learning into action.

Design
Design your learning loops to deliver the degree of statistical rigour in micro-surveys to give you the actionable insights your business needs to learn and progress.



Collect
Run frequent micro-surveys at touch-points and back them up with more in-depth assessments when required, for example, when a new innovation is being researched or launched.

Analyse
Break down the data collected. Review through the lens of chosen segments, for instance, demographics, location or touch-points. Triangulate and cross-reference to detect patterns or trends and benchmark against other business data, such as periodic in-depth assessments, to arrive at conclusions and insights. Visualise the findings to make the sharing of the data and insights easy to share and explain.

Discuss
Engage stakeholders. Validate the data and encourage dialogue and collaboration to arrange further targeted investigations if required (see step 2, in-depth assessments). Discuss and agree actions for improved alignment.

Correct
Take action and correct your alignment course if necessary. Set concrete deadlines for agreed alignment actions to be made (see innovation START-STOP-KEEP approach, Chapter 4.2) and keep communicating with stakeholders. Review and adjust your learning loops as necessary.

Learning Loops create a cycle of measurement, feedback and improvement. By regularly engaging stakeholders, organisations strengthen alignment, identify opportunities and adapt to change.

5.2 INTERNAL PERFORMANCE METRICS

The following statements provide a practical starting point for measuring internal performance and alignment with the SOI®. Used within a Learning Loop, they help assess how effectively the organisation's purpose, values and priorities are being translated into everyday practice.

1.0 Strategic Focus
1.1 The organisation has a clearly defined SOI® that guides decision-making.
1.2 There is a clear connection between the SOI®, organisational ambitions, strategic goals and day-to-day activities.
1.3 Progress towards strategic goals is regularly measured and reviewed.
1.4 The organisation's Core Values are understood and applied in practice.
1.5 The Positioning Statement clearly explains the value the organisation creates.
2.0 Leadership
2.1 Leaders communicate the SOI® consistently and credibly.
2.2 Leaders demonstrate the Core Values through their actions and decisions.
2.3 Leaders actively support alignment and continuous improvement.
3.0 Communications
3.1 The organisation communicates its purpose and priorities clearly.
3.2 Stakeholders are encouraged to participate in achieving organisational ambitions.
3.3 Communication channels support meaningful dialogue and feedback.
3.4 The organisation's communications are consistent with its actions.
4.0 Products and Services
4.1 Products and services reflect the organisation's SOI® and values.
4.2 Products and services continue to evolve in response to stakeholder needs and future challenges.
5.0 Processes and Systems
5.1 Organisational goals and measures are aligned with the SOI®.
5.2 Policies, processes and systems support the delivery of the SOI®.
5.3 Technology and data are used effectively to improve performance and create stakeholder value.
6.0 Innovation
6.1 The organisation actively seeks opportunities to improve and innovate.
6.2 Innovation efforts are aligned with the SOI®.
6.3 Feedback is regularly gathered and used to inform decision-making.
6.4 Employees are encouraged to contribute ideas and improvements.
7.0 People and Culture
7.1 People understand how their role contributes to the SOI®.
7.2 Employees receive the support needed to deliver organisational ambitions.
7.3 Performance management reflects the organisation's Core Values.
7.4 Behaviours that support the SOI® are recognised and celebrated.
7.5 The organisation fosters a culture of learning, collaboration and continuous improvement.

Learning loop // Micro-survey #03/2026

Please answer this short **two question** survey. It should take less than two minutes.
The survey is completely anonymous. Nobody will know what you, or any other individual, writes in this survey.
Please tell us what you truly feel! We will share the results of the survey and discuss them with you.

Question 1: Are you protected from pressures of any kind to perform tasks or work that are not consistent with our SOI®? (0=not at all; 10=very much)

○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

Question 2: Do you have the relationships and support that you need to contribute to our SOI®? (0=not at all; 10=very much)

○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

What is your gender?

○ Male ○ Female ○ Other

What is your age?

○ 18-22 ○ 23-38 ○ 39-54 ○ 55-73 ○ 74+

Thank you for contributing your thoughts. Your response helps us ensure we progress in the right way together.

5.3 INTERNAL IMPACT METRICS

Performance metrics help organisations understand how effectively they are delivering their ambitions and goals. Impact metrics help determine whether those efforts are creating meaningful value for people, stakeholders and society.

Some impacts will become visible quickly. Others may take years to emerge. For this reason, impact measurement should be viewed as an ongoing process of learning rather than a one-off assessment.

Learning Loops provide a practical way of gathering this insight by exploring two dimensions: perceived change and the quality of relationships.

Perceived Change helps identify whether stakeholders believe the SOI® is making a positive difference.

Quality of Relationships helps assess the levels of trust, collaboration and engagement required to sustain long-term success.

The following questions can be used within internal Learning Loops. Responses are typically scored on a scale of 1–10.

1.0 Perceived Change

1.1 Are positive changes occurring as a result of the SOI®?
1.2 Is the SOI® helping create a stronger organisational culture?
1.3 Do the Core Values contribute to a more inclusive and supportive workplace?
1.4 Do employees understand how their work contributes to the SOI®?
1.5 Do employees actively support the organisation's ambitions and values?

2.0 Quality of Relationships

2.1 Is it worthwhile for employees to engage in the SOI® and related initiatives?
2.2 Does the organisation focus on issues that matter to employees and stakeholders?
2.3 Are leaders accountable for delivering the SOI®?
2.4 Does the SOI® encourage collaboration across the organisation?
2.5 Do leaders listen to and act upon feedback?
2.6 Do employees feel able to challenge ideas and contribute new thinking?
2.7 Are employees encouraged to learn, adapt and improve?
2.8 Do employees have the relationships and support needed to contribute effectively?
2.9 Does the organisation foster strong collaboration with external stakeholders?

Additional questions can be explored through periodic reviews and in-depth assessments. However, Learning Loop surveys should remain short, focused and easy to complete in order to encourage regular participation and generate meaningful insight over time.



Regular communication, feedback and visible action help ensure the SOI® remains authentic and impactful. Frequent Learning Loops drive improvement more effectively than occasional surveys.

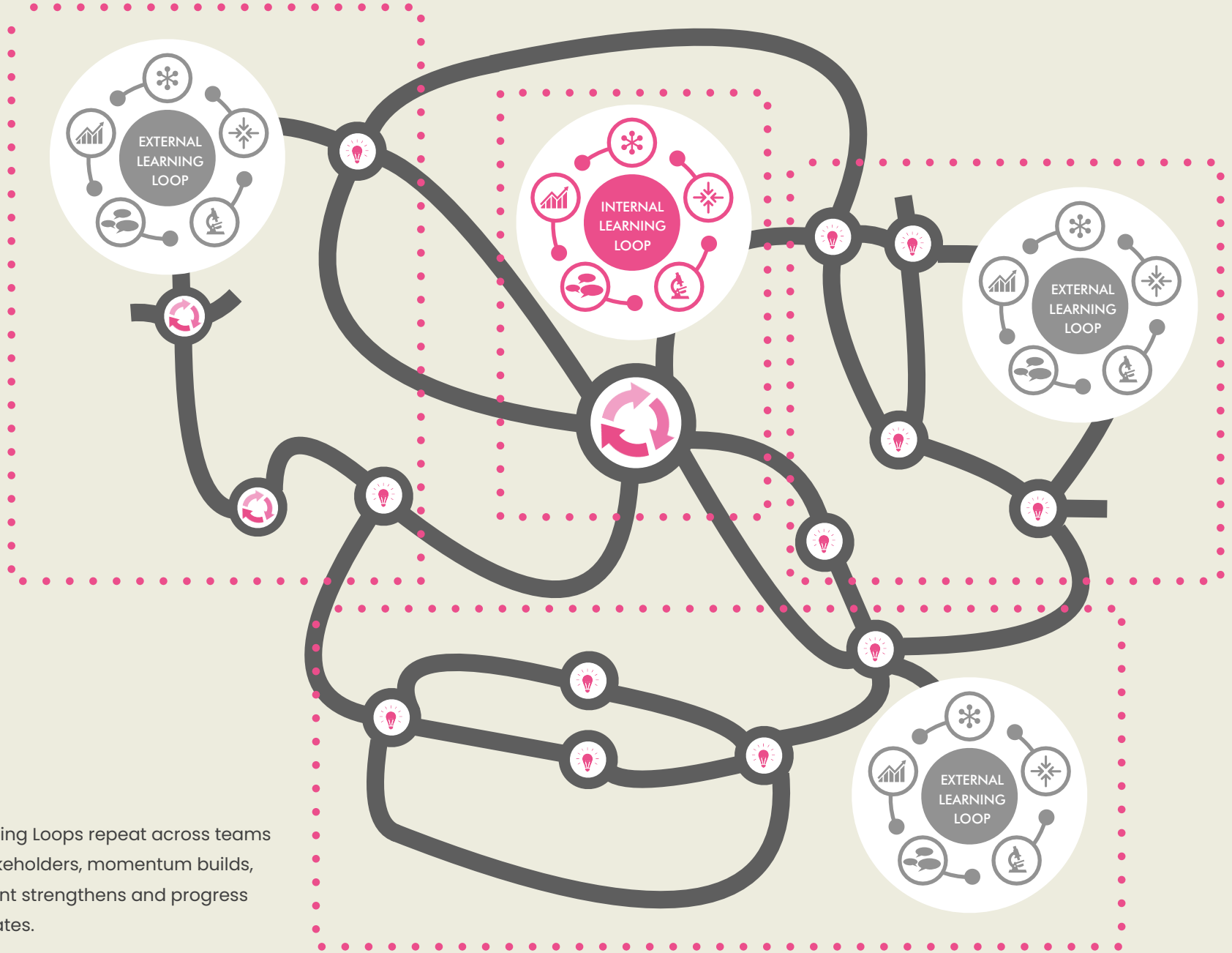
5.4 EXTERNAL LEARNING LOOPS

The same principles that govern Internal Learning Loops apply to external stakeholders. The difference lies in the questions being asked.

External Learning Loops help organisations understand how they are perceived by customers, suppliers, partners, investors, communities and other stakeholders. A combination of scored responses and open questions typically provides the richest source of learning.

1.0 Performance Metrics
The following statements can be scored using a scale of 1–10.
1.1 The organisation clearly communicates its purpose and strategic direction.
1.2 The organisation demonstrates a clear commitment to its SOI®.
1.3 The organisation's Core Values are evident in its actions and behaviours.
1.4 My experience of the organisation reflects its stated purpose and values.
1.5 The organisation demonstrates leadership within its sector.
1.6 Employees communicate consistently about the organisation's purpose and priorities.
1.7 The organisation encourages stakeholder participation and engagement.
1.8 The organisation has a positive reputation amongst its stakeholders.
1.9 The organisation's products and services contribute positively to the future needs of stakeholders.
2.0 Impact Metrics
Perceived Change *(Open Questions)*
2.1 What positive changes have you observed as a result of the organisation's purpose and activities?
2.2 What unintended, negative or missed impacts should the organisation be aware of?
Quality of Relationships *(Scale of 1–10)*
2.3 The organisation focuses on issues that are important to me and my stakeholders.
2.4 It is worthwhile engaging with the organisation to help improve its performance and impact.
2.5 The organisation's leaders are accountable for their commitments.
2.6 The organisation listens to and acts upon stakeholder feedback.
2.7 The organisation encourages learning, adaptation and continuous improvement.
2.8 I have the relationships, information and support needed to contribute effectively.
2.9 The organisation helps foster collaboration between stakeholders.
2.10 I trust the organisation to act consistently with its stated purpose and values.

External Learning Loops provide valuable insight into stakeholder perceptions, changing expectations and emerging opportunities. When reviewed alongside Internal Learning Loops, they help create a more complete picture of organisational performance and impact.



As Learning Loops repeat across teams and stakeholders, momentum builds, alignment strengthens and progress accelerates.

5.5 LEARNING TO THRIVE

Measurement is often viewed as the final stage of strategy implementation. In reality, it is the beginning of the next cycle.

The purpose of Learning Loops is not simply to collect data or produce reports. Their value lies in helping organisations understand what is working, what is not and where improvements can be made. Over time, this creates a culture of learning that strengthens alignment, improves performance and increases impact.

One of the most important lessons is that organisations do not create value in isolation. Every organisation operates within a wider ecosystem of employees, customers, suppliers, partners, communities and other stakeholders. The success of the SOI® therefore depends not only on what the organisation does, but also on the quality of the relationships and collaborations that surround it.

Learning Loops provide a practical mechanism for engaging these stakeholders in a shared process of learning and improvement. By participating, stakeholders help shape the future direction of the organisation and contribute to outcomes that benefit the wider ecosystem.

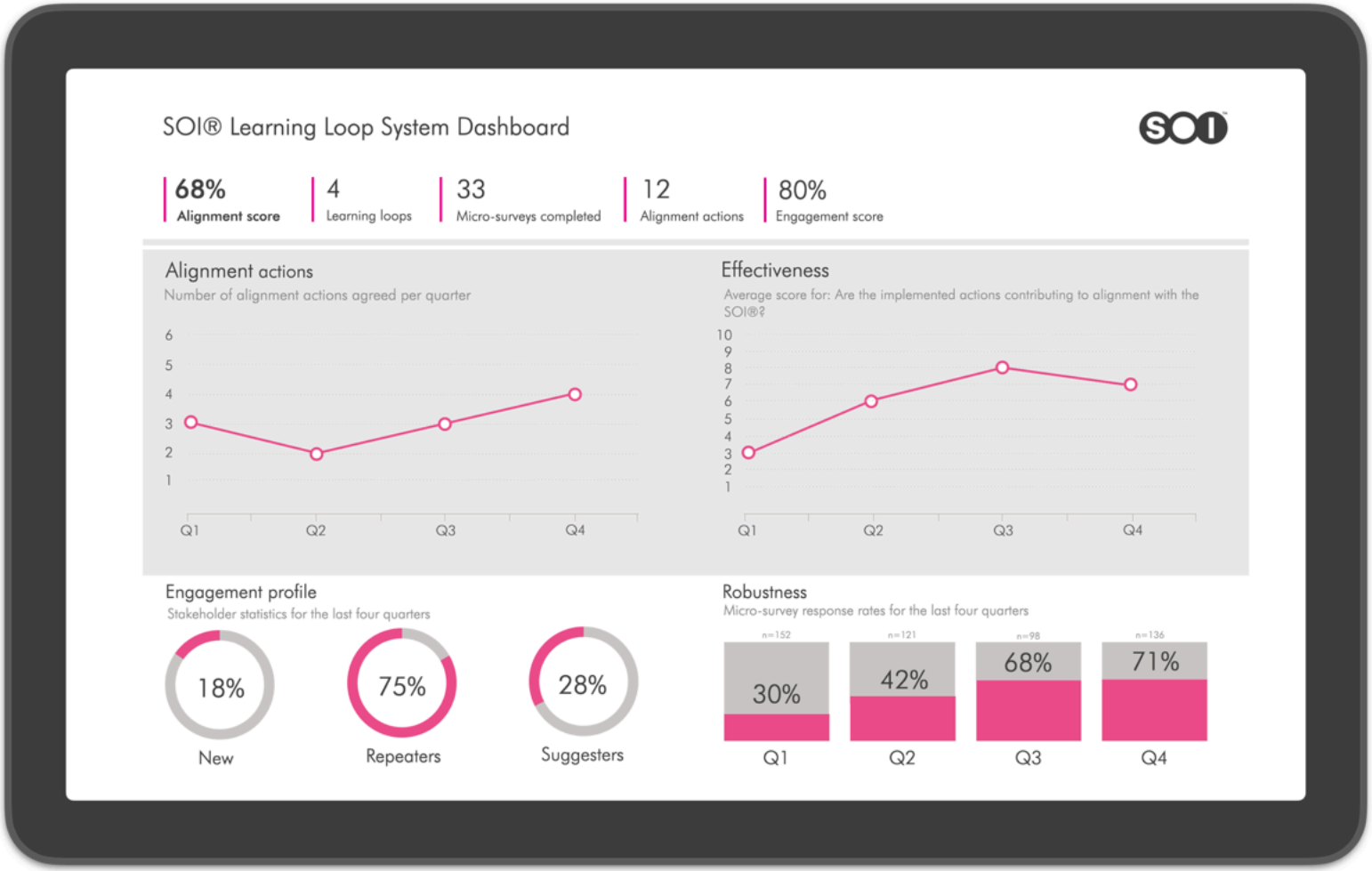
Simplicity is critical. The challenges organisations seek to address are often complex, but measurement systems do not need to be. Organisations are generally better served by focusing on a small number of meaningful indicators and acting on what they learn than by collecting vast quantities of data that rarely influence decision-making.

This simplicity helps create momentum. Small improvements, consistently identified and implemented, build confidence, strengthen engagement and reinforce progress. Over time, these incremental gains can have a significant cumulative impact.

Learning Loops therefore become much more than a measurement tool. They provide a practical framework for continuous improvement, adaptation and resilience.

Purpose provides direction. Alignment turns purpose into action. Learning enables organisations to improve and adapt over time.

Organisations that learn are better equipped to thrive. Those that thrive are better positioned to create lasting value for their stakeholders, society and the world around them.



Illustrative dashboard showing how performance, impact and Learning Loop data can be brought together in a single view. Digital tools and AI have the potential to help organisations monitor progress, identify trends and support better decision-making in real time.

KEY POINTS

- Measurement is not an end in itself. Its purpose is to generate insight that helps organisations learn, improve and create greater value over time.
- Learning Loops provide a practical framework for gathering feedback, measuring progress and turning knowledge into action.
- Performance metrics help determine whether ambitions, goals and priorities are being delivered. Impact metrics help assess whether those efforts are making a meaningful difference.
- Internal and external Learning Loops provide complementary perspectives that strengthen understanding, accountability and stakeholder relationships.
- Organisations that continually learn, adapt and improve are better equipped to thrive and create long-term value for their stakeholders, society and the world around them.

YOUR NOTES

SOI™

SINGLE ORGANIZING IDEA

6.0

101-113

RESOURCES

Gain more from SOI® Learn about ongoing support, how to get involved and a special bonus.

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6.4 ISO 37011 GOVERNANCE AND PURPOSE 113

6.5 TOOLS & TEMPLATES DIRECTORY 115

6.6 ENDORSEMENTS FOR SOI® AND CORE 117

6.1 GLOSSARY

Accountability The responsibility of an organisation and its leaders to explain, justify and take ownership of their decisions, actions and impacts. Accountability extends beyond financial performance to include stakeholders, society and the environment.

Alignment The process of ensuring that strategy, culture, leadership, communications, products, services, systems and behaviours support the delivery of the SOI®.

Ambition Statement A concise description of what success would look like if an organisation fully realised its SOI®. Ambition Statements help translate purpose into strategic goals and measurable outcomes.

Circular Economy / Circular Solutions An economic model that seeks to eliminate waste, keep materials in use for as long as possible and regenerate natural systems. It aims to decouple economic activity from the consumption of finite resources.

Core Values The commitments that guide the actions, behaviours and attitudes required to deliver the SOI®. Values define how things get done and provide a basis for decision-making, performance management and culture.

Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) A broad term describing how organisations manage their social and environmental responsibilities. CSR activities can range from isolated initiatives to fully integrated business strategies.

Customer Relationship Management (CRM) The processes, practices and technologies used to manage relationships and interactions with customers and other stakeholders.

Ecosystem The network of stakeholders, organisations and relationships that influence and are influenced by an organisation. An ecosystem typically includes employees, customers, suppliers, partners, investors, regulators, communities and competitors.

Enterprise Risk Management (ERM) A structured approach to identifying, assessing and managing risks that could affect an organisation's ability to achieve its objectives.

Environmental, Social and Governance (ESG) A framework used to assess an organisation's environmental performance, social impact and governance practices. ESG considerations are increasingly used by investors, regulators and stakeholders to evaluate long-term performance.

Impact Metrics Measures used to understand the difference an organisation is making for stakeholders, society and the environment.

International Organization for Standardization (ISO) An independent, international body that develops standards designed to improve quality, safety, efficiency and consistency across products, services and systems.

ISO 37011 An international standard providing guidance on the governance of organisations by purpose. It helps organisations embed purpose into decision-making, accountability and long-term value creation.

Kaizen A Japanese philosophy of continuous improvement that encourages individuals and teams to seek regular, incremental improvements to performance and effectiveness.

Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) Measures used to monitor progress towards strategic goals and organisational objectives.

Learning Loops A structured process for gathering feedback, measuring performance and impact, identifying opportunities for improvement and implementing change. Learning Loops help organisations continuously learn and adapt.

Net Promoter Score (NPS) A widely used customer loyalty measure based on a single question: "How likely are you to recommend this organisation to others?" NPS provides a simple indicator of customer advocacy and satisfaction.

Performance Metrics Measures used to monitor progress against organisational ambitions, strategic goals and operational objectives.

Positioning Statement A concise statement explaining why an organisation exists, the value it creates and how it seeks

to make a difference. Together with the SOI® and Core Values, it forms part of the SOI® Strategic Framework.

Purpose An organisation's meaningful reason to exist. In a purpose-driven organisation, purpose guides decisions, strategy, behaviour and value creation, helping ensure the organisation contributes to the long-term wellbeing of people, society and the natural environment.

Purpose Washing The practice of promoting a purpose or social commitment without embedding it meaningfully into organisational strategy, decision-making or behaviour. Similar to greenwashing.

Silos Departments or teams that operate independently with limited communication, collaboration or information sharing across an organisation.

Single Organizing Idea (SOI®) A strategic approach and framework for making purpose real. SOI® helps organisations identify, define, align and measure the impact of a core purpose that guides decisions, behaviours, governance, operations and stakeholder value creation.

Stakeholder Any individual, group or organisation that can affect, or be affected by, an organisation's activities, decisions or performance.

Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) The 17 global goals adopted by United Nations Member States in 2015 to address poverty, inequality, climate change, environmental degradation, peace and prosperity by 2030.

Sustainable Prosperity The creation of long-term economic, social and environmental value in a way that meets present needs without compromising the ability of future generations to meet theirs.

Shared Value A concept developed by Michael Porter and Mark Kramer describing policies and practices that enhance organisational competitiveness while simultaneously improving social and economic conditions in the communities where an organisation operates.

SOI® Strategic Framework The combination of an organisation's SOI®, Core Values and Positioning Statement. It provides the strategic foundation for alignment, decision-making and performance.

Stakeholder Capitalism A model of capitalism that recognises organisations create long-term value by serving the interests of all stakeholders, including employees, customers, suppliers, communities, investors and the environment.

Systems Thinking An approach to problem solving that focuses on understanding the relationships and interdependencies between parts of a system rather than viewing issues in isolation. Systems thinking is particularly valuable when addressing complex societal and organisational challenges.

Theory of Change A framework that describes how and why a desired change is expected to happen. It maps the relationship between activities, outputs, outcomes and long-term impact, providing a basis for planning and measurement.

Touchpoint Any point of interaction between an organisation and its stakeholders. Often referred to as a "moment of truth" because it influences perceptions, experiences and relationships.

Triangulate The process of validating findings by comparing information from multiple sources, perspectives or methods to improve confidence and accuracy.

6.2 SOI® PROJECT PLANNING CHECKLIST

The checklist below provides a practical guide to planning and preparing an SOI® project. Every client engagement will differ in scope, scale and complexity, but the activities listed here will help ensure the foundations for a successful project are in place.

PROJECT DEFINITION

☐ Clarify project objectives and desired outcomes.
☐ Confirm project scope, deliverables and timelines.
☐ Identify key stakeholders and decision-makers.
☐ Establish project governance and reporting arrangements.
☐ Confirm budget, resources and responsibilities.
☐ Agree project success criteria.

RESEARCH AND DISCOVERY

☐ Review existing strategic plans, business plans and annual reports.
☐ Review purpose, mission, vision and values statements.
☐ Review customer, stakeholder and employee research.
☐ Review brand, communications and marketing materials.
☐ Review relevant industry, market and competitor information.
☐ Identify key trends, risks and opportunities.

STAKEHOLDER ENGAGEMENT

☐ Identify internal stakeholders to be interviewed.
☐ Identify external stakeholders to be interviewed.
☐ Confirm interview schedule and sequencing.
☐ Prepare interview questions and briefing materials.
☐ Schedule workshops and participant groups.
☐ Prepare workshop invitations and communications.

WORKSHOP PREPARATION

☐ Confirm workshop objectives and outputs.
☐ Prepare workshop exercises and materials.
☐ Prepare tangible and intangible attribute lists.
☐ Prepare stakeholder and touch-point mapping exercises.
☐ Confirm venue, technology and logistics.
☐ Allocate facilitation and note-taking responsibilities.

DEFINE PHASE

☐ Review workshop and interview findings.
☐ Identify emerging themes and insights.
☐ Draft candidate SOI® options.
☐ Draft Core Values.
☐ Draft Positioning Statement.
☐ Complete initial stress testing.
☐ Refine and validate the SOI® Strategic Framework.

ALIGN PHASE

☐ Define Ambition Statements.
☐ Identify strategic goals and priorities.
☐ Establish measures and KPIs.
☐ Review organisational systems, processes and policies.
☐ Identify alignment opportunities across key functions.
☐ Develop implementation roadmap and responsibilities.

MEASURE PHASE

☐ Define performance metrics.
☐ Define impact metrics.
☐ Establish Internal Learning Loops.
☐ Establish External Learning Loops.
☐ Confirm reporting and review cycles.
☐ Identify opportunities to utilise AI and digital tools to support analysis and learning.

DELIVERY

☐ Prepare final presentation and supporting materials.
☐ Confirm implementation priorities and next steps.
☐ Agree governance and review arrangements.
☐ Establish accountability for delivery.
☐ Schedule follow-up reviews and Learning Loop activities.

FINAL CHECK

☐ Is the SOI® clear, relevant and inspiring?
☐ Are the Core Values actionable and meaningful?
☐ Does the Positioning Statement accurately reflect reality?
☐ Are ambitions, goals and KPIs aligned?
☐ Is there a clear implementation pathway?
☐ Is there a practical mechanism for learning and continuous improvement?
☐ Will the work help the client organisation create greater commercial, social and environmental value?

6.3 AI AND NG&A

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is rapidly transforming the way organisations gather insight, process information, make decisions and create value. At Neil Gaught & Associates, we embrace AI as a powerful enabler that enhances the quality, speed and effectiveness of our work while remaining firmly grounded in human judgement and expertise.

AI supports many aspects of our methodology, including research, stakeholder analysis, interview preparation, data synthesis, trend identification, scenario development and content creation. It enables us to process large volumes of information quickly, uncover patterns that might otherwise be missed and explore a wider range of strategic possibilities.

However, AI is not a substitute for experience, wisdom, empathy, leadership or purpose. The most effective solutions emerge through a combination of human insight and technological capability. We often describe our approach as being built on three foundations: Truth, Informed Intuition and Intelligent Synthesis.

Purpose remains the organising principle that guides our work. AI helps us accelerate learning, improve decision-making and enhance outcomes, but it is always applied in service of a clearly defined purpose. Used responsibly, AI strengthens our ability to help clients create positive commercial and societal outcomes in an increasingly complex world.

USING AI IN THE SOI® PROCESS

Research

AI can rapidly gather, summarise and analyse information from multiple sources, helping Associates:

- Review annual reports, websites and strategic documents.
- Analyse industry trends and competitor activity.
- Identify emerging risks and opportunities.
- Generate stakeholder and market insights.
- Summarise large volumes of information quickly.

AI should be viewed as a research assistant rather than a research authority. Findings should always be validated through independent review and stakeholder engagement.

Interviews

AI can support interview preparation by helping Associates:

- Develop interview guides.
- Generate probing questions.
- Identify themes for exploration.
- Summarise interview transcripts.
- Highlight recurring patterns and insights.

However, the quality of an interview depends on trust, active listening and the ability to respond to what is being said in the moment. These remain uniquely human skills.

Workshops

AI can help prepare workshop materials and support facilitation by:

- Generating exercises and discussion prompts.
- Identifying common themes.
- Assisting with idea clustering and synthesis.
- Producing workshop summaries and outputs.

The role of the facilitator remains critical. Great workshops rely on human interaction, energy, curiosity and the ability to navigate differing perspectives.

Define

AI can help Associates explore alternative wording and concepts for:

- Single Organizing Ideas (SOI®).
- Positioning Statements.
- Core Values.
- Strategic narratives.

AI can generate options quickly, but final decisions should always be informed by the evidence gathered and the judgement of the project team.

Align

AI can support implementation planning by helping to:

- Draft ambition statements.
- Develop strategic goals.
- Identify potential KPIs.
- Create implementation plans.
- Analyse alignment opportunities across functions.

Measure

AI can be particularly valuable during the Measure phase by:

- Analysing survey responses.
- Identifying trends and patterns.
- Monitoring stakeholder feedback.
- Generating dashboards and reports.
- Highlighting emerging issues and opportunities.

Used well, AI can help organisations transform large volumes of information into practical insight.

Principles for responsible use

Associates should ensure that AI is used responsibly and transparently.

As a general guide:

- Human judgement should always take precedence over AI-generated recommendations.

• Confidential and sensitive information should be handled carefully and in accordance with client requirements.
• AI-generated content should be reviewed and validated before use.
• Stakeholder engagement should never be replaced by automated analysis alone.
• AI should accelerate learning and decision-making, not determine them.

Final thought

The organisations most likely to benefit from AI will not be those that automate everything. They will be those that combine technology with human insight, creativity and purpose.

Used thoughtfully, AI can help Associates work more efficiently, uncover deeper insights and create greater value for clients. It is a powerful accelerator, but it is people who ultimately define purpose, make decisions and create meaningful change.

6.4 ISO 37011 GOVERNANCE AND PURPOSE

ISO 37011

ISO 37011 is the world's first international standard dedicated specifically to the governance of organisations by purpose. Developed by experts from around the world under the auspices of the International Organization for Standardisation (ISO), it provides guidance to boards, leaders and organisations seeking to place purpose at the centre of decision-making, strategy and long-term value creation.

The significance of ISO 37011 lies in its recognition that purpose is not simply a statement or aspiration, but a governance responsibility. It encourages organisations to consider the interests of stakeholders alongside financial performance and to align culture, leadership, strategy, systems and measurement around a clearly defined reason for existence.

Neil Gaught has contributed to the development of ISO 37011 and sees it as a natural complement to the Single Organizing Idea (SOI®) methodology. While ISO 37011 provides guidance on what purpose-led governance looks like, SOI® provides a practical framework for identifying, defining, aligning and measuring purpose throughout an organisation.
Together, they help organisations move beyond rhetoric and towards meaningful action, ensuring that purpose becomes embedded in governance, operational practice and organisational culture.

The relationship between ISO 37011 and SOI®

ISO 37011 provides guidance on governing organisations by purpose. The SOI® methodology provides a practical framework for identifying, defining, aligning and measuring purpose across an organisation. Put simply: ISO 37011 explains what good purpose governance looks like. SOI® helps organisations make it happen.

The two approaches share a common objective: helping organisations create sustainable value for stakeholders while improving long-term organisational performance.

GOVERNANCE IN ACTION

Good purpose governance is not about creating additional bureaucracy. It is about ensuring that leaders regularly ask a small number of important questions:

- Are we acting consistently with our purpose?
- Are we creating value for stakeholders?
- Are our decisions aligned with our long-term ambitions?
- Are we measuring what matters?
- What are we learning and how should we respond?

These questions help organisations maintain focus while adapting to changing circumstances and stakeholder expectations.

LOOKING AHEAD

The growing importance of sustainability, stakeholder expectations, transparency and long-term value creation means purpose governance is likely to become an increasingly important feature of organisational life.

ISO 37011 provides an internationally recognised framework for this journey.

For Associates, understanding the principles of purpose governance will become an increasingly valuable capability. The organisations best positioned to thrive in the future will be those that can successfully align purpose, governance, performance and stakeholder value.

The SOI® methodology provides a practical pathway for doing exactly that.

6.5 TOOLS & TEMPLATES DIRECTORY

The tools described in this directory are intended to support, not replace, professional judgement. The most effective Associates understand when to use them, how to adapt them and how to combine them in ways that create meaningful value for client organisations and their stakeholders.

IDENTIFY

Stakeholder Mapping Matrix
Identifies internal and external stakeholders, their influence, interests and concerns.

Stakeholder Workshop
Explores stakeholder perceptions, expectations and priorities.

Touch-point Mapping
Identifies key moments of interaction between an organisation and its stakeholders.

Interview Framework
Structured approach for gathering insight from internal and external stakeholders.

Desk Research Template
Framework for analysing strategy, governance, culture, market and stakeholder information.

DEFINE

SOI® Strategic Framework
Defines the Single Organizing Idea®, Core Values and Positioning Statement.

Core Values Development Exercise
Supports the identification and refinement of values required to deliver the SOI®.

Positioning Statement Development Tool
Helps create a concise and compelling explanation of the organisation's purpose and value.

SOI® Stress Test
Tests the strength, relevance and long-term viability of the proposed SOI®.

ALIGN

SOI® Alignment Canvas

Translates the SOI® Strategic Framework into ambitions, goals, actions, responsibilities and measures.

Ambition Statement Framework

Defines what success would look like if the SOI® were fully realised.

Start–Stop–Keep Exercise

Identifies activities that should begin, cease or continue in support of the SOI®.

Innovation Programme Framework

Encourages employees and stakeholders to generate ideas aligned with the SOI®.

MEASURE

Learning Loops Framework

Provides a structured process for gathering feedback, generating insight and driving continuous improvement.

Internal Performance Metrics

Measures the degree to which the SOI® is being embedded across the organisation.

Internal Impact Metrics

Assesses the difference the SOI® is making for employees and organisational culture.

External Learning Loops

Captures stakeholder perceptions, experiences and expectations.

Performance and Impact Dashboard

Provides a visual overview of progress, outcomes and opportunities for improvement.

PROJECT DELIVERY

Presentation proposal and project preparation templates.

6.6 ENDORSEMENTS FOR SOI® AND CORE

"CORE: The Playbook is a breakthrough practical guide that global business leaders will use to become the vanguards for the world we want. And I fully expect it will become a critical resource for schools educating the global managers of today and the future." Dr. Sanjeev Khagram, Dean & Director General, Professor of Global Leadership Thunderbird School of Global Management, University of Arizona

"The SOI® toolkit is a way that businesses can embark on a journey toward mutual prosperity that is both simple and scalable. Now, more than ever, solutions that encompass the need for sustainable and ethical business are key – the SOI® is such a solution." Rajiv Joshi, Former MD of The B Team

"21st-century problems need powerful and practical 21st-century solutions to escalate progress, and Single Organizing Idea is one of them." James Wallis, Co-founder of IBM Blockchain

"CORE: The Playbook is just how a book ought to be in the 2020s: short, accessible, original and full of clear practical guidance that enables companies to make the radical but necessary changes that the planet and people urgently need. For anyone who's starting to feel that the new corporate agenda is too much talk and not enough action, this is the remedy." Simon Anholt, Policy advisor and researcher

"As we enter a decisive decade companies need to shift from ambition to action. The CORE Playbook is a practical guide for businesses to do just that." Ben Kellard, Director of business strategy, the Cambridge Institute for Sustainability Leadership (CISL)

"An essential guide to building a 21st-century business where everyone feels great about contributing to a more meaningful and sustainable future." Patrick Grant, celebrity fashion designer and founder of Community Clothing

"Finally, a practical guide that not only shows you how to put purpose at the core of your business, but also provides the measurement tools to prove you're delivering sustainable prosperity for all." Chip Conley, *New York Times* bestselling author, strategist and entrepreneur

"The SOI® uses a structured methodology that helps teams hold the core purpose central to all their actions, relationships and communications. B Corps, and any organisation that is serious about being led by their purpose to do more than just seek profit, could be helped by this book." Katie Hill, Executive Chair, B Lab Europe

"The most important lesson I have learned from my 50+ years of working with organisations on their values and culture is the necessity for a comprehensive cut-through accountability mechanism that supports the embodied living of values and the behaviours that demonstrate them. In CORE: The Playbook, for the first time, we have an approach and a tool with that power." Gunther M Weil, Ph.D., Co-Founder & CEO of Value Mentors

"There's an urgent need for tools to help small and medium sized business to pivot and change for good, and here is a practical resource to help them do just that." Nigel Topping, High Level Climate Action Champion, UNFCCC COP26

"If you're a business leader anywhere in the world and are looking to align your business activity with the challenges of the moment I recommend you read this book and discover the many valuable tools that could help you transform your business culture and practice." Kumi Naidoo, formerly Secretary General, Amnesty International, and Executive Director Greenpeace

"Now, more than ever, solutions that encompass the need for sustainable and ethical business are key – the SOI® is such a solution." Rajiv Joshi, Former Managing Director of The B Team

"An essential guide to building a 21st-century business where everyone feels great about contributing to a more meaningful and sustainable future." Patrick Grant, Businessman, celebrity fashion designer, founder of Community Clothing

"Timely, engaging, valuable and practical." Zahid Torres-Rahim, Founder, Business Fights Poverty

"Read Neil's book CORE because it's got some really practical advice about how to get started." Karen Hamilton, VP Sustainable Business, Unilever

"I enjoyed this book, learned from it and strongly recommend it for those trying to succeed at the interface between business and society." John Elkington, Conceiver Triple Bottom Line

"The story dramatically brings home the new reality of extreme global connectivity." Prof David Grayson CBE, Co-author *All In*

"No business can prosper in the future without a clear purpose and here at last is a practical management tool to turn a great theory into gritty reality." Mike Barry, Director of Sustainable Business (Plan A) at Marks and Spencers

"SOI® has so much more potential to make a difference than a simple purpose." Charles Handy, leading business management thinker

"When you have a core idea at the heart of your business, as cooperatives tend to in focusing on member needs, there can be arichness of motivation and a special kind of empowered collaboration at work. Keep it simple and you can bring more people on board." Ed Mayo, Secretary General, Co-operatives

"At a time when organisations are struggling to cope with the pace of change, managers need a method to focus their best efforts. This book offers precisely that." Charles Arthur, Former Technology Editor *The Guardian* 2009-14.

"This is a great reflection on the movement beyond CSR to one that connects business –through purpose – to the real issues our societies need to deliver on. It's a great recipe for future success – and one that is much needed. It will be a good practical reference for any organisation wanting to make a positive difference." Rachel Brown, Founder & CEO, NZ Sustainable Business Network

"Business should help people learn how they can live better lives and lead society to create the systems and technologies to do so. CORE is a great guide to how business can take on that task." Charles Leadbeater, author of *We Think*



NG&A



SUBSTACK


NG&A
SOI